

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi lights and camera flashes, the opening film SIRÁT. But the message was clear: Delhi beyond the glamour lies a

For a city that has always told stories through its streets, its monuments, and its restless crowds, this is a new chapter. Delhi is not just hosting a festival. It is rehearsing a role.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Budget nearly triples allocation for tourism sector, says Kapil Mishra

The Delhi airport handled around 32 lakh foreign tourist arrivals in 2024, the highest in the country, according to the Economic Survey of Delhi 2025-26 presented on Monday.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



commodities. "We are maintaining strict vigil and taking action against illegal activities involving essential supplies," he said, adding that such operations will continue to

According to officials, the premises were being used to stockpile both domestic and commercial LPG cylinders. The accused allegedly procured cylinders through unauthorised channels and sold them to local residents and small businesses at higher rates.

property in joint ownership along with his Son Late Saurav Solanki S/o Gianinder Singh Solanki 1st Floor, 10M School, 72/66614, Noida, U.P.

LOST & FOUND
Shobhit Makhija S/o Late Inder
umar Makhija R/o A17, Third
floor, East of kailash, New Delhi-
110065, have lost original
partnership deeds of firm Milawa
am Lakhmi Chand 368, 369, Main
adar Bazar Delhi 110006, dated
1954, 1986, 2016, 2021 on 21st
March 2026. Finder May contact
me At 9899917276.

PUBLIC NOTICE

notice is hereby given that the original documents relating to the property bearing Plot No. 149, Subplot No. 01, Block A, Sector-37, Phoolka, New Delhi, in the name of Smt. Phoolka Kak, have been lost/misplaced on or about 08 December 2025 in and around Gagan Vihar, New Delhi. The loss of the aforesaid documents has been duly reported to the concerned Police Station. The lost documents include: Demand-cum-encumbrance Letter, Possession Letter, Lease Deed, Registration Certificate, Possession Slip, Mutation Register, Lease Deed, Registration Certificate and Conveyance Deed. Any person having any claim/objection with respect to the aforesaid documents may contact the undersigned within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which necessary action shall be taken for issuance of certified/duplicate copies from the concerned authorities.

Smt. Phoolka Kak
154, Gagan Vihar, 2nd Floor New
Delhi-110051 Mobile: 8527532110

FOR MY MONEY SECURITIES LIMITED CIN : L67120DL1992PLC047890 Regd. Office : 10-A, UNDER HILL LAKE, CIVIL LINES, DELHI-110054 Email id : mymoneyservices@outlook.com, Contact No.: 011-47067455, 47087300			
RESULT OF POSTAL BALLOT Pursuant to the provisions of Section 110 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 and Regulation 44 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the Resolution seeking approval of the Members, by means of Postal Ballot i.e. by way of remote e-voting process only ("e-voting") and any other applicable laws and regulations, for the following businesses as proposed vide Notice dated February 14, 2026 have been passed as per Report dated March 24, 2026 submitted by Ms. Sarika Jain Prop Sarika Jain & Associates (Membership No. FCS 8185), Practicing Company Secretaries, being the Scrutinizer appointed for the purpose and are enumerated as under			
S No	Particulars	Resolution	% of Total Valid Votes cast in favor of the Resolution
1.	Appointment of Mr. Rakesh, DIN : 11331598 as an Independent Director of the Company	Special	100
2.	To make a material modification into Material-Related party transactions entered by way of lease and rent deposit agreement with the Late Mr.Govind Narain Seth promoter	Special	99.91

Kejriwal saw himself as emperor, people as slaves: CM Rekha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday tabled a detailed account in the State Assembly, alleging serious financial irregularities in the construction of former Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal's residence, and said those who built a 'Sheesh Mahal' in Delhi have now moved into what she described as a 'Sheesh Mahal-2' in Punjab.

She accused Kejriwal of behaving like an emperor, claiming he saw himself as a ruler while treating the people of Delhi as slaves. At her request, the House referred the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) report

to the Public Accounts Committee (PAC) for a detailed probe.

Rekha Gupta stressed that the issue was not merely about bricks, furniture or interiors, but about exposing what she called a 'well-planned deception' that had been hidden for years.

According to her, the report reflects a deeper moral decline, where a leader who projected himself as a representative of the common man allegedly embraced a lifestyle of excess and entitlement.

Quoting a couplet, she remarked, 'Wo zahar deta to sabki nigah mein aa jaata, usne yoon kiya ki dava dena band kar diya' (Had he given poison, it would have been

obvious; instead, he chose to withhold the medicine).

Questioning Kejriwal's image of simplicity, she pointed out that he had once criticised former Chief Minister Sheila Dikshit for having 10 air conditioners but allegedly built a residence equipped with 50 ACs and 70 fans.

She also raised concerns over the timing, noting that while Delhi was battling the COVID-19 pandemic and people were losing their lives, construction of the residence continued.

The Chief Minister further alleged that the property included high-end features such as a lift costing several lakhs just to transport food, premium refrigerators and



imported coffee machines.

She said as many as six private consultants were hired for different aspects of the project, including interiors, furniture and landscaping. She questioned how the project cost escalated from an initial ₹8 crore to ₹62 crore, calling it a matter that warrants thorough investigation.

Presenting a detailed list of figures in the House, the Chief Minister said that this display of extravagance was not limited to Arvind Kejriwal alone. His associates also allegedly misused public money extensively. She stated that Manish Sisodia spent ₹7.5 crore of public funds on his residence.

Similarly, ₹2.33 crore was spent on the renovation of Rakhi Birla's residence, while former Speaker Ram Niwas Goel spent ₹3.23 crore. Former minister Gopal Rai spent ₹2.55 crore, Satyendar Jain ₹2 crore, and Imran Hussain and Rajendra Pal Gautam spent ₹3 crore each on upgrading their homes.

Additionally, Saurabh Bharadwaj spent ₹1 crore of public money on improvements to his residence.

She argued that at a time when Delhi needed investment in roads, flyovers and core infrastructure, the government was focused on creating 'world-class' interiors for official residences. The promise of simplicity, she said, remained only a slogan,

while the reality reflected a culture of extravagance.

Rekha Gupta further alleged that the residence was never opened to the public and was not used for public hearings, adding that ordinary citizens had no access. "Those who claimed they would change politics only ended up changing their homes," she said.

The Chief Minister assured that her government would ensure every rupee of public money is spent on development. She called for strict action against those found guilty, and the House unanimously approved her proposal to refer the matter to the Public Accounts Committee for further investigation.

Sheesh Mahal row erupts in Assembly

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A political storm erupted in the Delhi Assembly on Wednesday after Cabinet Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh cited CAG findings to attack the previous Government over the alleged escalation in the cost of a bungalow project, dubbed "Sheesh Mahal".

The Minister claimed the cost of the residence rose sharply from ₹7 crore to ₹58 crore, calling it a "serious breach of public trust" and a symbol of misplaced priorities.

Opening his address, Singh said the issue reflected a deeper gap between promises made to the public and actions taken in office. He alleged that commitments of simplicity were quickly abandoned after assuming power. "Within 20 days, the people of Delhi were misled. The promise of simplicity turned into a symbol of luxury," he told the House, referring to the allotment of a bungalow at Flagstaff Road soon after the previous



Government took office.

The Minister drew a sharp contrast between the construction of the residence and the COVID-19 crisis. "When Delhi was struggling for oxygen and families were searching for hospital beds, one file alone was marked 'Most Urgent'. That file was for the construction of a palace," he said.

Citing the CAG report, Singh claimed that no files related to essential services such as water supply, sewer systems, pollution control, or pandemic response were given similar urgency over the past

several years. He said funds allocated for COVID relief were not fully utilised, even as expenditure on the bungalow increased. The Minister pointed out that while the Government of India had provided ₹787.91 crore for COVID relief, a portion of it remained underutilised.

He further emphasized that if this amount had been used for ICU infrastructure, thousands of lives could have been saved. "At a time when one ICU bed cost around ₹15,000, this amount could have created more than 2,300 ICU beds," he said.

CAG raps DJB for failing to repay ₹66,595 crore loan

RAJESH KUMAR
■ New Delhi

The Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) on Wednesday rapped the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) for failing to repay loans worth ₹66,595 crore accrued over a period of 10 years and recommended that it explore ways and means for the collection of the huge amount of dues outstanding from the consumers to improve its financial position.

The audit noted that the outstanding loan of DJB increased from ₹25,140 crore (April 2017) to ₹34,540 crore (March 2022). Moreover, the interest on the accumulated loan was ₹32,055 crore (March 31, 2022). However, DJB had not repaid any loan to the Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi (GNCTD) since 2013-14, and the total outstanding loan and interest was Rs 66,595 crore as of March 2022.

The CAG report on DJB was tabled in the Delhi Assembly. In its reply to the auditor, the

DJB stated that it is a non-profit organisation with the main objective of supplying water to more than 26 lakh consumers of Delhi, which comes under essential household service.

To provide a water supply, the Delhi Government grants loans to DJB because the income of DJB from the supply of water is not enough to repay the loan amount; therefore, it has requested the Government to convert the loans into grants. The decision is still pending with the Delhi Government. The auditor rejected the DJB reply, saying this is not acceptable, as it did not make rigorous efforts to either periodically revise the water/sewage charges or make efforts for the recovery of dues pending from the consumers in order to meet its expenses. The matter was referred to the Government in July 2023; a reply has been awaited since April 2025.

The report further highlighted that in 2021-22, there has been a 23 per cent

AUDIT SUMMARY: DJB FINANCIAL CRISIS	
1. DEBT PROFILE (AS OF MARCH 2022)	
■ Total Outstanding Debt:	₹66,595 crore.
■ Principal Loan:	₹34,540 crore (Increased from ₹25,140 crore in 2017).
■ Accumulated Interest:	₹32,055 crore.
■ Repayment Status:	Zero repayment to the Government of NCT Delhi (GNCTD) since 2013-14.
2. REVENUE & BILLING INEFFICIENCIES	
■ Non-Revenue Water:	Out of 743 MGD produced, only 371 MGD (50%) was billed.
■ Billing Accuracy:	Only 66% of billed water was based on actual meter readings; 33% was unmetered/estimated.
■ Collection Gap:	The shortfall in revenue collection worsened from 30.5% (2017-18) to 50.5% (2021-22).
■ Customer Dues:	Outstanding dues from consumers/departments rose by 65% in a single year (reaching ₹21,696.89 crore in 2021-22).

increase in the principal amount (from ₹4,325.66 crore to ₹5,335.46 crore) and a 65 per cent overall increase (from ₹13,123.69 crore to ₹21,696.89 crore) in outstanding dues from customers, government departments, etc., including the Late Payment Surcharge (LPSC).

Last year, Delhi Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh

Verma had stated that DJB is staring at an unprecedented financial crisis, with pending water bills of around ₹1.42 lakh crore across the city.

"In three categories, we have identified that the commercial category has the highest amount of dues ₹66,000 crore followed by the government category ₹61,000 crore and then

domestic ₹15,000 crore," said Verma. The audit also noted that the total distribution of potable water was 743 MGD (2021-22), against which DJB had billed only 371 MGD (50 per cent). Moreover, only 244 MGD (66 per cent) out of this was billed on the basis of actual metre readings. Thus, 33 per cent of the potable water supplied was not billed as per actual meter readings.

The report highlighted that though the number of active water connections increased consistently and there was an overall increase of about 16 per cent in the number of water connections during the period under review, the quantum rise in water bills was not commensurate with this.

Further, the shortfall in collection of water charges increased from 30.5 per cent in 2017-18 to 50.5 per cent in 2021-22. This, besides being indicative of inadequate effort on the part of DJB to improve revenue collection, also raises questions on the accuracy of the billing process itself.



सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार



श्री राम नवमी की हार्दिक शुभकामनाएँ



भारत प्रभु कृपाला दीनदयाला कौसल्या हितकारी ।
हरषित महतारी मुनि मन हारी अद्भुत रूप बिचारी ॥



IN FOCUS



Indian Air Force's (IAF) Surya Kiran Aerobatic Team (SKAT) performing manoeuvres during a display over the Sainik School Sujanpur Tira in Hamirpur district, Himachal Pradesh

India rejects Pakistan's remarks on Asiya sentencing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India on Wednesday strongly rejected Pakistan's comments on the sentencing of Kashmiri separatist leader Asiya Andrabi, asserting that Islamabad has no locus standi to intervene in India's internal affairs or judicial processes. Responding to a statement issued by Pakistan's Foreign Office, Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said India "categorically rejects" any comments made in support of a banned terrorist organisation and its members.

"The reaction from Pakistan is not surprising," Jaiswal added, pointing to a long-standing pattern of backing terrorism. "Instead of peddling lies and frivolous narratives, Pakistan should introspect on the grave and systematic human rights violations it continues to perpetrate," the MEA statement said. The remarks come a day after a Delhi court sentenced Andrabi to life imprisonment in a terror-related case. Two of her associates, Sofi Fehmeeda and Nahida Nasreen, were handed 30-year jail terms.

The order was pronounced by Additional Sessions Judge Chander Jit Singh at the Karkardooma Courts, who noted that the actions of the convicts threatened the "very existence of India" and were aimed at the secession of



Asiya Andrabi

Jammu and Kashmir.

The court observed that the accused had not abhorred violence, but instead indirectly promoted it by glorifying militants and propagating a secessionist ideology.

The case stems from a 2018 investigation by the National Investigation Agency into the activities of the banned outfit Dukhtaran-e-Millat, founded by Andrabi. The prosecution alleged that the group used social media, public speeches, and other platforms to advocate for Jammu and Kashmir's merger with Pakistan.

Andrabi was convicted UAPA, including charges related to conspiracy for terrorist acts and membership of a terrorist organisation, along with offences under the Indian Penal Code such as criminal conspiracy and waging war against the State.

The court rejected pleas for leniency, stating that activities aimed at destabilising the nation and promoting secessionist ideology warranted stringent punishment, reinforcing India's zero-tolerance stance on terrorism.

Tourism emerged as key economic driver during 9 years of Yogi govt: Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Tourism and Culture Minister Jaiveer Singh on Wednesday said that tourism has emerged as a key driver of economic growth during the nine years of the Yogi Adityanath Government. He highlighted a shift in the state's development model from what he termed a "graveyard economy" to a "temple economy".

Addressing the media at Lok

Bhawan here, Singh said the transformation was structural, linking tourism growth with employment generation, local livelihoods and global visibility.

Highlighting that the Government views tourism as a major economic engine rather than a standalone sector, he said the state's cultural profile has gained global recognition, with Lucknow being designated a UNESCO Creative City of Gastronomy in 2025.

According to a press statement,



FCRA Bill sparks row in Lok Sabha

Critics, including Congress and Trinamool MPs, warned that the measure concentrates excessive power in the executive and could lead to quasi-expropriation of NGO assets, disproportionately affecting rights-based and policy-focused organisations. Supporters argue the amendments plug operational loopholes left after the 2020 revisions and ensure transparency, accountability, and protection against misuse, while aligning penalties with proportionality and easing judicial burden.

The 2026 Bill thus continues a trend toward centralised oversight of foreign-funded entities, balancing administrative clarity with concerns over civil-society autonomy.

Govt orders PNG shift, tightens LPG access

The policy also aims to optimise LPG distribution by redirecting supplies from areas with PNG access to regions lacking such infrastructure, while promoting fuel diversification. Officials said the reforms are intended to improve ease of doing business through time-bound clearances, standardised charges and streamlined procedures for faster project execution. Separately, the Central Consumer Protection

Authority (CCPA) has cracked down on hotels and restaurants levying additional charges such as "LPG charges", "gas surcharge" or "fuel cost recovery" on consumer bills. In an advisory issued Wednesday, the CCPA said such charges cannot be imposed automatically. "The price displayed in the menu shall be the final price, exclusive only of applicable taxes," it said, warning that violations would be treated as unfair trade practices under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019. The advisory follows reports and social media posts showing eateries adding "gas crisis" fees to bills amid LPG shortages. Authorities clarified that input costs like fuel and electricity must be built into menu pricing and cannot be passed on as compulsory add-ons.

Iran rejects US push for 15-point truce proposal

Pakistan has emerged as a key intermediary, with Asim Munir facilitating backchannel communications, though Tehran's hardline stance complicates negotiations.

The conflict has severely disrupted global trade and energy flows. Nearly 20 million barrels per day of crude oil normally pass through the Strait of Hormuz, but access has fallen to 3.5-5.5 million barrels. LNG exports from Qatar and the UAE are constrained, while storage limits and attacks on infrastructure have forced Saudi Arabia to scale back production.

Over 1,000 Indians evacuated from Iran amid West Asia conflict: MEA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Amid the West Asia conflict, a total of 1,043 Indian nationals, including 717 students, have crossed out of Iran with the assistance of the mission in Tehran, the Ministry of External Affairs said on Wednesday.

At an inter-ministerial briefing here on the West Asia situation, Aseem R Mahajan, Additional Secretary (Gulf), MEA, also said the overall flight situation continues to improve, and that around 4.26 lakh passengers have returned from the region to India since February 28.

"During this period, a total of 2,149 flights, including scheduled and non-scheduled flights of Indian



Aseem R Mahajan

as well as foreign carriers, have operated from the region to India," he said.

The MEA said it continues to closely monitor the evolving situation in the Gulf and the West Asia region.

"We are according the highest priority to ensure the safety, security, and well-being of the large Indian community in the region," Mahajan said. The

ministry's dedicated Control Room remains operational to address queries and support Indian nationals and their families.

"We continue to assist travel of Indian nationals in Iran through Armenia and Azerbaijan, to India. A total of 1,043 Indian nationals, including 717 students and 326 other Indian citizens, have crossed out of Iran with our mission's assistance. "We are also facilitating travel of Indian nationals from Israel via Jordan to India. In view of the flight restrictions from Kuwait, Bahrain and Iraq, we continue to facilitate travel of Indian nationals via Saudi Arabia," he added.

Mahajan said the mortal remains of an Indian national who had passed away on

March 18 in an attack in Riyadh, have arrived in India earlier on Wednesday.

"We have been in regular touch with the family and express our deepest condolences to them at this difficult time," he said.

The Indian missions in Oman, Iraq, and the UAE are in regular touch with the concerned authorities regarding a missing Indian national and for early repatriation of the mortal remains of the other deceased Indian national, the MEA official said.

On Tuesday evening, MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar met the Iranian envoy in India and talked about the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

Harish Rana's last rites conducted, family to donate his organs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ghaziabad

Don't cry, he is in a happy place now, the parents of Harish Rana, the first person in India to be permitted passive euthanasia, said on Wednesday as they bid farewell to their son one last time.

Harish's last rites were conducted at the Green Park cremation ground in South Delhi on Wednesday morning, marking a quiet end to his 13-year ordeal.

In a final act of generosity, Harish's family consented to donate five of his organs.

The 31-year-old man passed away on Tuesday after slipping into a coma in 2013, following a fall from a fourth-floor balcony while he was



a B.Tech student at Panjab University. During the last rites, Harish's mother bid an emotional farewell to her son with folded hands and met those present, while his father Ashok Rana urged mourners not to cry, a neighbour said. Residents who attended the

cremation described the atmosphere as deeply emotional. Tejas Chaturvedi, a resident of the Raj Empire Society, noted that many attendees were moved to tears during the ceremony. However, Ashok Rana continued to console others and encouraged them to remain strong in their moment of grief. "Let no one weep.

I am praying that my son may depart in peace. Wherever he is born next, may he receive God's blessings," he said. Uttar Pradesh Congress chief Ajai Rai, who visited the cremation ground to pay his respects, said that the family had confirmed the donation of five of Harish's organs. "Harish might be gone, but he will continue to live on through the beneficiaries of his

organ donation. The family has set an example before the entire nation," Rai said. Family members, along with representatives of the Brahma Kumaris, a spiritual movement led by women, attended the cremation to offer their prayers for Harish.

Residents from the Raj Empire Society in Ghaziabad, where the Rana family lives, also came to show their support, joining a diverse group of NGOs, AIIMS staff, relatives, and friends.

Harish's body was transported to the cremation ground in an ambulance, and the platform was covered in rose petals. Many mourners paid their last respects with folded hands, and some placed saffron garlands on the

body before it was laid upon the pyre. Ashish Rana, Harish's younger brother, lit the pyre, accompanied by his sister, Bhavna.

Sister Lovely of the Brahma Kumaris, who has been associated with the family and travelled to the cremation ground, said that meditative chants were performed during the last rites. "The body is leaving the mortal world, but the soul is immortal and has begun a new journey," she said. "The family decided to donate Harish's eyes," Sister Lovely said.

Additionally, Sister Lovely shared that a 'bhog' (offering) and prayer ritual will be held by the Brahma Kumaris in the coming days, where food items that Harish enjoyed will be prepared.

Pakistan, Afghan nationals chargesheeted in drug case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate on Wednesday said it has filed a chargesheet against certain nationals of Pakistan, Afghanistan and India as part of a money laundering investigation into a 2019 case of smuggling of over 580 kg of heroin along the Attari-Wagah international border check post in Punjab.

The prosecution complaint (chargesheet) was filed before a special Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) court in Mohali on Monday, the federal probe agency said in a statement. The ED said its



probe found that 890 kg of heroin and 52 kg of mixed narcotics was smuggled from Pakistan to the Land Customs Station (LCS) at Attari in Amritsar by concealing the contraband in imported bags of light pink rock salt in June 2019.

A total of 18 entities have been named as accused, including nationals of Pakistan, Afghanistan and India.

Noida airport inauguration: Admin on high alert regarding security, traffic

PRESS TRUS OF INDIA
■ Noida

The Uttar Pradesh Government on Wednesday said preparations for the inauguration of Noida International Airport by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on March 28 have reached final stages.

The district administration is working on road footting to ensure a smooth



inauguration ceremony, the Government said in a statement issued in the state capital Lucknow. All departments are rapidly completing their assigned responsibilities, it added.

According to the statement, this ambitious project has been translated into reality owing to active and continuous efforts of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath.

FROM PAGE - 1

Fertilizer exports are also affected, threatening agricultural output, and maritime insurance and logistics costs have surged.

The human toll mounts: over 2,000 deaths have been reported, including 1,200 in Iran, 1,000 in Lebanon, 17 in Israel, and 15 in the US. Iran maintains the Strait of Hormuz is open to vessels not linked to its "enemies," emphasizing diplomacy but insisting on cessation of aggression and restoration of trust.

Analysts warn the coming weeks will be decisive, determining whether diplomatic channels can succeed or whether the conflict will further destabilize the region and global markets.

Reckless for reach: Social media warping road...

But these are reactive measures, chasing visibility rather than preventing behaviour. By the time a video goes viral, the damage is often already done. This is no longer a law-and-order issue alone-it is a systemic failure that demands coordinated intervention. The Ministries of Information Technology and Road Transport must step in decisively. Platforms must be compelled to identify, throttle, and demonetise dangerous driving content at scale. The technology to do this already exists; what is missing is the will to enforce it.

At the same time, penalties for such behaviour must become swift, certain, and severe. Licence

suspensions, heavy fines, and criminal charges where warranted should not be exceptions-they should be the norm. Public roads cannot be allowed to function as arenas

CAPF Bill faces heat over IPS dominance

The provision effectively nullifies a May 2025 judgment of the Supreme Court of India, which granted Organised Group A Service status to CAPF officers and directed a gradual reduction in IPS deputation up to IG rank to address stagnation and morale concerns.

The Government has defended the move, stating IPS officers are vital for Centre-state coordination, especially in internal security operations such as counter-insurgency, elections and disaster response. The Bill also proposes cadre restructuring and additional senior posts to accelerate promotions for around 13,000 officers.

However, the legislation has triggered strong backlash from serving and retired CAPF personnel, who argue it entrenches IPS dominance and further narrows their promotion avenues. Officers point to long delays-often 15-18 years-for initial promotions, despite leading high-risk operations. Protests have been held at Jantar Mantar, with veterans calling the Bill "discriminatory" and a reversal of judicial gains. Critics say it institutionalises "outsider leadership"

despite CAPFs' operational track record.

Opposition parties have also objected, seeking referral to a parliamentary committee and questioning procedural lapses.

Supporters, including some security analysts, argue the Bill brings administrative clarity and strengthens national security coordination. Critics counter that it departs from the court's vision of building indigenous leadership within CAPFs. As the Bill heads for debate, it has reignited a long-standing fault line between IPS officers and CAPF cadres over leadership, promotions and institutional autonomy.

Jaipur bus overturns in Karol Bagh, two dead...

The bus, bearing Rajasthan registration RJ-14PE-5065, was en route from Jaipur to Fatehpuri in Sadar Bazar. Though it had a seating capacity of 70, it carried about 30 passengers at the time. Driver Pankaj Kumar, 26, from Alwar, Rajasthan, has been detained and is undergoing treatment at Lady Hardinge Medical College.

Investigators are recording passenger statements and conducting a technical inspection of the vehicle to determine the cause. Police officials credited the prompt coordination of officers and locals for limiting casualties.

The incident underscores the hazards of overnight highway travel and the importance of strict safety adherence.

Amit Shah hails passage of UCC Bill in Gujarat

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday hailed the passing of Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill by Gujarat Assembly and said the country should be run not on the basis of appeasement, but through equal laws for all citizens.

In a post on 'X' in Gujarati, Shah said it has been the BJP's resolve since its inception that there should be a uniform law for every citizen in the country.

He said under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the BJP-ruled States are continuously moving forward in this direction.

Shah said he was delighted that after Uttarakhand, Gujarat has now also accomplished the "historic task" of passing the UCC Bill, thereby demonstrating its commitment.

"For this, I congratulate Chief Minister Shri @Bhupendrabjp and all the legislators who supported this bill. The country should be run not on the basis of appeasement, but through equal laws for all citizens-this is both our priority and our resolve," he said.

On Tuesday, the Gujarat



Assembly passed the UCC Bill that seeks to put in place a common legal framework to govern marriage, divorce, succession and live-in relationships irrespective of religion after a marathon debate of more than seven hours.

The Bill stipulates seven years of jail term if marriages are conducted through force, coercion, or fraud, and also prohibits bigamy and polygamy.

It also makes registration of marriages and live-in rela-

tionships mandatory.

The ruling BJP hailed the Bill, which exempts tribals, as a landmark reform to ensure equality, while the Congress vehemently opposed it saying it violates fundamental right and was "anti-Muslim".

The Bill was passed with majority voice vote as Opposition Congress and Aam Aadmi Party did not approve it and demanded that it be sent to the State assembly's select committee.

Cabinet clears modified UDAN scheme with ₹28,840 crore outlay



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Revamping the regional air connectivity initiative, the Union Cabinet on Wednesday cleared a modified UDAN scheme with an outlay of ₹28,840 crore for ten years that will provide funds for developing airports, related operations and maintenance activities, helipads and support for acquisition of India-made aircraft.

Airlines will be provided Viability Gap Funding (VGF) for operating UDAN routes, and the amount is estimated to be ₹10,043 crore over the ten-year period starting from FY 2026-27. Briefing media persons after the Cabinet meeting, Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said that under the modified scheme, 100 airports would be developed from existing unserved airstrips with the help of State Governments, and the outlay in this regard would be ₹12,159 crore over

the next eight years.

Scheme aims to develop 200 modern helipads at ₹15 crore each, amounting to a total requirement of ₹3,661 crore over the next eight years (inflation-adjusted), an official release said.

The focus will be to develop helipads in priority and aspirational districts to improve last-mile connectivity and emergency response. Towards Operation & Maintenance (O&M) works, the scheme will provide support for three years, capped at ₹3.06 crore per annum per airport and ₹0.90 crore per annum per heliport/water aerodrome.

The total amount is estimated to be ₹2,577 crore for around 441 aerodromes, the release said.

According to the Government, the funding is being proposed, given the high recurring O&M costs and limited revenue streams for the Regional Connectivity Scheme (RCS)-only aerodromes.

BJP releases names of 19 more candidates for Bengal polls

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Wednesday released another list of 19 candidates for the West Bengal Assembly polls, fielding Arup Kumar Das from Singur seat and Madhumita Ghosh from Haripal.



According to the list, Rathindra Nath Bose will contest from Coochbehar Dakshin, Chitrajit Roy from Islampur, Ratna Debnath from Panihati, and Biplab Mandal from Howrah Madhya.

Sankar Guchhait will enter the fray from Medinipur seat, Anil Singh from Naihati, Subir Nag from Chunchura and Dipanjan Chakraborty from Uttarpara. Polling in West Bengal is slated to be held in two phases on April 23 and April 29. The results will be out on May 4.

Nation Focus



458 inmates benefit from poor prisoners scheme: Govt in RS

As many as 458 prisoners have benefited so far under the Centre's 'Support to Poor Prisoners' scheme, the Government informed Rajya Sabha on Wednesday. This information was given in response to a question by TMC MP Saket Gokhale, who asked whether the Government could State the "reasons why the undertrial population in Indian prisons remains chronically above 75 per cent, despite the introduction of fast-track courts and digitised bail systems; the status of the 'Support for Poor Prisoners' scheme; and whether Government is considering a statutory cap on prison occupancy rates". In the written reply, Minister of State for Home Affairs Bandi Sanjay Kumar said the scheme, launched in 2023, aims to provide financial assistance to prisoners who are unable to pay fines or secure bail due to financial constraints.

CIABC urges States price revisions on alcoholic beverages

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Escalating geopolitical tensions in the Middle East, the impact is now being more acutely felt by India's alcoholic beverage industry, which was experiencing sustained cost pressures across its value chain prior to the Iran war.

Against this backdrop, the Confederation of Indian Alcoholic Beverage Companies (CIABC) is writing to State Governments seeking consideration for price revisions of IMFL



products. Anant S Iyer, Director General, CIABC, said the industry has emphasised that timely and calibrated price adjustments are essential to ensure continued investments, maintain stable supply, and

support the long-term sustainability of the sector.

The rise in USD vide the INR has further caused spikes.

In addition to higher fuel and transportation costs, manufacturers are also witnessing significant cost escalations in packaging materials such as PET, aseptic formats, and other polymer-linked inputs, all of which are closely tied to global energy price movements. These increases are cumulative in nature and are adding to the overall cost of production for the industry. Refer annexure.

Over 1,800 IAS and IPS posts vacant: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As many as 1,300 posts of the Indian Administrative Service (IAS) and 505 belonging to the Indian Police Service (IPS) are lying vacant, the Lok Sabha was informed on Wednesday.

Of the total of 6,877 sanctioned posts of the IAS, there are 5,577 officers in position, Union Minister of State for Personnel Jitendra Singh said in a written reply.

There are 4,594 IPS officers in position, as against their sanctioned strength of 5,099, he said. Singh explained that IAS posts are filled according to the reservation guidelines issued by the Government.

"Since 2012, a total of 180 candidates have been recruited to the IAS through the civil services examination each year, with 4 per cent of these seats reserved for candidates with benchmark disabilities (PwBD)," he said.

He added that the process of allocating candidates through the civil services



examination (CSE), conducted by the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC), is ongoing and continuous. Vacancies are regularly assessed, and all advertised IAS vacancies are filled while considering the reservation norms, Singh added.

Currently, there are no backlog vacancies in the Indian Administrative Service. Additionally, there are no backlog reserved posts in the Indian Police Service as of January 1, 2025, Singh added. The minister noted that over the past five years, 245 candidates from the Other Backward Classes (OBC), 135 from Scheduled Castes (SC), and 67 from Scheduled Tribes (ST) have been appointed to the IAS.

Congress MP seeks hike in MPLAD funds to ₹20 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress Rajya Sabha member Pramod Tiwari on Wednesday said the allocation of ₹5 crore per annum for MPs under the MPLAD scheme was "quite less," and it should be increased to at least ₹20 crore, besides abolishing GST on works carried out under the scheme.

Under the Members of Parliament Local Area Development Scheme (MPLADS), each Member of Parliament (MP) is allocated ₹5 crore per annum to recommend development projects focusing on durable community assets like infrastructure, health, and education.

Raising the matter during the Zero Hour in the House, Tiwari described the MPLAD scheme as the most effective tool for members of Parliament to fulfil the basic needs of their electoral constituencies.

BRO to build 1,600 km infrastructure along Indo-Myanmar border

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Underlining the crucial role of infrastructure, including roads in border areas for further strengthening defence preparedness, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Wednesday said the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) is fostering an ecosystem encompassing national security, development, and connectivity.

Making this assertion while chairing a parliamentary consultative committee meeting for the Ministry of Defence on the BRO, he acknowledged its efforts



towards enhancing connectivity in the North-Eastern region and in areas affected by Left-Wing Extremism, thereby contributing to security and regional development.

"The BRO has facilitated the mobility of defence forces, and worked towards bringing a positive transformation in the lives of the

residents," the minister said. He added that the BRO has been entrusted with the task of developing infrastructure along the Indo-Myanmar border, spanning approximately 1,600 kilometres, an initiative that will further bolster the border management capabilities.

The progress under the Border Roads Development Programme 2023-28, under which over 1,000 road and infrastructure projects are being executed, including new construction, upgradation and maintenance works to further strengthen border connectivity, was also discussed during the meeting.



ATTENTION! GST TAXPAYERS

Whose Aggregate Annual Turnover# is upto a specified limit* can opt for GST Composition Scheme for the FY 2026-2027 by 31st March, 2026

Eligible taxpayers who wish to avail the Composition Scheme can follow these steps on the GST portal (www.gst.gov.in):



Log in to the Taxpayers' Interface



Go to Services > Registration > Application to Opt for Composition Levy



Fill the FORM GST CMP-02 and submit

Those eligible taxpayers, who are already availing Composition Scheme, need not file FORM CMP-02 if they are eligible.



Easy & Convenient Compliance



Attractive Tax Rates



Minimum Compliance Requirements



Auto Continuation/Renewal and Easy to Opt-out



Available for supplier of Goods as well as Services



Less Bookkeeping

* Type of Suppliers	# Aggregate Annual Turnover during FY 2025-26
Supplier of Goods	Taxpayers registered in 08 Specified States
	upto ₹75 Lakh
Supplier of Services	Taxpayers registered in other States
	upto ₹150 Lakh
upto ₹50 Lakh	

For more details, please refer to section 10 of CGST Act, Rule 3-7 of CGST Rules and Notification No. 14/2019 - Central Tax dated 07.03.2019

GST Composition Scheme: Big Benefits for Small Taxpayers

 @cbicindia

 @cbic_india

 @cbicindia

 @CBICINDIA

 @CBIC india

CBC 15502/13/0051/2526

States Focus



MANIPUR CM, BIHAR GOVERNOR CALL ON PRESIDENT MURMU

Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh on Wednesday called on President Droupadi Murmu at the Rashtrapati Bhavan. The President's office shared a picture of the meeting in a social media post. "Chief Minister of Manipur Yumnam Khemchand Singh called on President Droupadi Murmu at Rashtrapati Bhavan," it said. Singh was sworn in on February 4 as the 13th Chief Minister of Manipur. In another post, the President's office said that Bihar Governor Lt General Syed Ata Hasnain (retired), along with his spouse Sabiha Hasnain, also called on Murmu. Hasnain was sworn in as the Governor of Bihar on March 14.



NBA LAUNCHES SHORT-TERM INTERNSHIP FOR STUDENTS

The National Biodiversity Authority (NBA) has launched a short-term internship programme for undergraduate and postgraduate students to offer hands-on, project-based learning through active engagement with NBA programmes, officials said. "The programme is designed to build capacity, deepen environmental awareness, and significantly enhance employment opportunities for young people in the biodiversity conservation and natural resources management sectors and also to develop them as biodiversity ambassadors," a senior official said.

Cabinet extends IVFRT scheme to upgrade visa services

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved a five-year extension of the Immigration, Visa, Foreigners Registration and Tracking (IVFRT) Scheme, committing ₹1,800 crore to modernise and secure the country's immigration system through March 2031.

The Cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, approved the continuation of the scheme from April 1, 2026, to March 31, 2031, a Government statement said.

The continuation of the scheme is not just a "technical upgrade, but a strategic transformation" aligned with the vision of the Government to promote international mobility through a world-

class immigration and visa issuance system, it said.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah said the cabinet's decision to continue with the scheme for five years is a decisive step towards Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision for making immigration to India simpler.

"It will further modernise visa-granting process and make travel and business within India seamless for our guests, while guarding India's security goals," he said on 'X'.

The IVFRT Scheme was first approved in May 2010 by the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs, with an outlay of ₹1,011 crore and a duration until September, 2014. It was extended in 2015, 2017 and 2021.

In January 2022, the Cabinet extended the scheme through March 31, 2026, with



an allocation of ₹1,365 crore.

The latest extension follows the enactment of the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, which has heightened the need for a stronger, more adaptable IVFRT system to address evolving travel demands and future challenges in immigration control

and foreigner management, including illegal migration.

The next phase will focus on three areas — emerging technology innovations, transformation of core infrastructure, and technology and service optimisation.

Planned measures include mobile-based services, self-

Nagaland CM Rio calls for Naga unity across cultural and political spheres

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kohima

Nagaland Chief Minister Neiphiu Rio on Wednesday called for strengthening Naga unity across political, cultural and social spheres, stating that even if physical integration remains a challenge, collective identity must be preserved.

Addressing the first Tenyimi Youth Cultural Festival at Naga Heritage Village, Kisama, Rio said integration of contiguous Naga areas remains a longstanding aspiration and a key negotiating point between the Nagas and the Centre.

"Even if we cannot be physically integrated, we must remain united politically,



emotionally, socially and culturally," he said.

The festival was organised by the Tenyimi Union Nagaland (TUN), comprising five tribes Angami, Chakhesang, Pochury, Rengma and Zeliang — to promote cultural exchange and unity among the youths.

Rio stressed that shared traditions, customary laws and history bind the Naga

people together, and called for reconciliation and collective effort to secure a dignified and honourable resolution to the Naga political issue. The chief minister noted that the Centre had recognised the distinct identity of Nagas, citing protective provisions such as the Bengal Eastern Frontier Regulation of 1873 and Article 371A.

400 security camps to become schools, hospitals in Bastar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jagdalpur

The Bastar region, along with the rest of Chhattisgarh, has largely emerged from the grip of decades of "red terror" with plans underway to convert nearly 400 security camps, once the pivot of anti-Maoist fight, into public infrastructure like schools, the Government said on Wednesday.

Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Sharma, who holds the Home portfolio, announced that security camps would be gradually converted into schools, hospitals and centres for the collection and processing of minor forest produce.

He was addressing a programme on surrender and rehabilitation of former Maoists at Shaurya Bhavan, the Police Coordination Centre at Jagdalpur, and the Bastar district headquarters. On the occasion, senior Maoist commander Papa Rao, among the last remaining top leaders of the insurgency, formally surrendered along with 17 other cadres.

Their surrender, announced on Tuesday, took place under the State Government's "Poona Margem (from rehabilita-



tion) to social reintegration) initiative.

"Today, Bastar and the entire Chhattisgarh are out of the clutches of red terror. Bastar is ready to move ahead swiftly on the path of development," declared Sharma at the event organised less than a week before the Centre's deadline to eliminate Naxalism.

He cautioned against misinformation and stressed that Bastar's vast natural resources — 'jal, jungle, zameen' (water, forest, and land) — belong exclusively to local communities, particularly the youth, who must safeguard them.

The Government has a clear vision to boost economic growth in the region through minor forest produce, the Deputy Chief Minister maintained.

Sharma said around 400 security camps established in the interior regions of Bastar would be phased out and converted into development centres.

Maharashtra amends law to protect identities of acid attack victims'

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Legislative Council on Wednesday unanimously passed the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (Maharashtra Amendment) Bill 2026 to include provisions in the Shakti Bill to protect the identities of acid attack victims and ensure jail term for digital sexual overtures. The Bill to amend the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) in its application to the State of Maharashtra was earlier passed by the Assembly.

Speaking in the council, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, who also heads the Home department, said that the Shakti Bill was passed by the State legislature in 2020 and sent to the Centre for the President's assent.

The President had subsequently sent it back.



BJP slams Karnataka Govt for cancelling conference on Deendayal Upadhyaya

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka BJP President BY Vijayendra on Wednesday charged the Congress Government in the State of indulging in "hate politics" and "political interference", as he criticised its decision to cancel a conference on Hindutva ideologue Deendayal Upadhyaya's philosophy, scheduled at KSOU premises in Mysuru.

He urged Higher Education Minister M C Sudhakar to allow the event to be held. "*Ekatma Manava Darshan* — Bharat's



Worldview, an international academic conference, was to be organised by the Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee Research Foundation at the Karnataka State Open University.

Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan was supposed to attend the event, but the State

Government has all of a sudden ordered the cancellation of the event and has issued a notice to the Vice Chancellor," Vijayendra said. Speaking to reporters, he said, "This is nothing but hate politics." "They are obstructing even the event being organised at the university. This Government has brought a Bill against hate speech during the Belagavi legislature session, but action has to be taken against the State Government (for hate). Such political interference, even in the field of education, is not good for the Government," he

said, as he urged the minister to rectify the mistake and allow the event to be held.

The Department of Higher Education on Tuesday cancelled the three-day conference. Earlier, KSOU Vice-Chancellor Sharanappa V Halase was served a show cause notice for permitting the event to be held at the university. Minister Sudhakar on Tuesday defended the Government's decision to stop the event, saying public universities must remain apolitical and free from ideological influence.

Expressing concern over

the university's association with the organisers, he said, "It is shocking that our university has joined hands with them. The Vice-Chancellor himself is the reception committee chairman."

According to an earlier release by organisers, the "Ekatma Manava Darshan", International Academic Conference was scheduled to be held from March 25 to March 27 at the Convocation Hall of KSOU, Mysuru, in collaboration with Prajna Pravah, Karnataka, and the Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee Research Foundation.

Karnataka forms advisory panel to boost palliative care



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The Karnataka Government has constituted a State-level technical advisory committee to guide the planning, implementation and monitoring of palliative care services in the State, officials said on Wednesday.

The move follows a proposal noting that palliative care aims to improve the quality of life of patients and their families facing serious and life-limiting illnesses, they said. The Committee, chaired by Retired IAS officer Dr Raj Kumar Khatri, comprises members from Government health departments, leading Bengaluru-based medical institutions, and a representative from NGOs working in palliative care, officials said.

According to an official order dated March 23, the committee that will act as the main technical advisory body for palliative care in Karnataka would advise the Government on preparation, implementation and review of the State Palliative Care Policy and guidelines.

NIT Rourkela gets patent for gait-based intruder detection

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Researchers at the National Institute of Technology (NIT), Rourkela, have secured a patent for a fully automated system that recognises intruders based on their walking patterns to detect unauthorised access in large and complex building environments, according to officials. The "unauthorised person detection using thermal imaging and gait recognition for intra-building security" system introduces a next-generation solution to address the challenge of monitoring unauthorised access in large and complex building environments, they said.

According to Samit



Ari, Professor, Department of Electronics and Communication Engineering, conventional CCTV camera-based surveillance systems require extensive manual monitoring and analysis, making them ineffective and prone to human errors.

"In large setups, tracking individuals across multiple cameras is difficult, particularly under varying lighting

conditions and occlusions. To address these limitations, we developed a fully automated, non-intrusive system that can detect, identify, and track individuals using thermal imaging technology," Ari said.

"The innovation is designed to monitor suspicious activities. The integrated thermal imaging technology helps distinguish

humans from the background due to lower infrared noise and enables accurate detection even in inadequate lighting conditions," he added.

To achieve this, the research team used human gait as a biometric identifier, which recognises individuals based on their unique walking pattern, thus reducing the need for manual monitoring.

"When a person enters a restricted area, the system compares their walking pattern with those of authorised individuals. If no match is found, it flags the individual as suspicious and alerts security. We developed a working prototype with three thermal cameras connected to a central server via USB interfaces.

VHP hails SC ruling on Scheduled Caste status

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) on Wednesday welcomed the Supreme Court's verdict that only Hindus, Sikhs and Buddhists can be recognised as Scheduled Castes, saying it strengthens the basic spirit of the Constitution, social justice, and rule of law.

In a press statement, VHP joint general secretary Surendra Jain said the ruling is in line with the spirit of the Constitution. The ruling States that only followers of only the three communities will be considered to be under the



Scheduled Castes category.

"The decision is an important step towards establishing social harmony, transparency, and justice in the country," Jain said. He said the VHP workers will prepare a list of all those who have converted and ensure that these rights are restored to the deserving.

IITs, JNU and BITS Pilani among world's top 50: QS rankings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Four Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) and Birla Institute of Technology (BITS), Pilani are among the world's top 50 institutions for different subjects, according to the latest Quacquarelli Symonds (QS) World University Rankings announced on Wednesday.

London-based QS Quacquarelli Symonds, known for the university rankings, has published the 16th annual edition of the QS World University Rankings by Subject.

The rankings benchmark more than 21,000 academic



programmes across 1,900 universities in over 100 countries, spanning 55 disciplines and five broad faculty areas.

According to the rankings, India records 27 top 50 positions across subjects and broad faculty areas —

more than double the 12 recorded in 2024 — earned by 12 institutions.

Leading the individual charge is the Indian School of Mines University, Dhanbad, ranked 21st globally in Mineral and Mining

Engineering, and IIM Ahmedabad, which ranks 21st in both Business and Management Studies and Marketing. The latter is a subject debut — India has never before appeared in Marketing's global rankings.

Among the top 50 are IIT Bombay, Kharagpur and Madras; JNU and BITS Pilani.

"India's rise this year is not just about scale: it's about momentum in quality and global competitiveness. The breadth of improvement across engineering, technology and business signals a system that is accelerating with intent. The next phase will be defined by how effectively institutions deepen research strength, build

global partnerships, and sharpen their distinctiveness on the world stage," said Jessica Turner, CEO, QS Quacquarelli Symonds.

IIT Delhi has delivered the edition's most complete single-institution performance. It records six top-50 entries, leads India in four subjects — Chemical Engineering (48th, its first top-50 appearance), Electrical and Electronic Engineering (36th), Mechanical, Aeronautical and Manufacturing Engineering (44th, best in over a decade), and the Engineering and Technology broad area (36th) — and ranks second in Computer Science at 45th.

Your Trusted Management Advisory

www.transglobeadvisors.in

Order Order

Karnataka HC quashes FIR against Sri Sri Ravi Shankar in land encroachment case



The Karnataka High Court on Wednesday quashed the FIR against Art of Living Foundation head and spiritualist Sri Sri Ravi Shankar in connection with a case registered against several persons for alleged land encroachment.

Justice M Nagaprasanna passed the order on a plea filed by Sri Sri Ravi Shankar to quash the case against him.

The FIR in which Sri Sri Ravi Shankar is named, is tied to a public interest litigation (PIL) petition filed in 2023 by one Chandra Sekaran N and some others. The PIL sought demolition of some structures that were allegedly built by encroaching on Government land in Kaggalipura village, Uttarahalli Hobli, Bengaluru South Taluk. Sri Sri Ravi Shankar was among the respondents named in this PIL for having allegedly been involved in the land encroachment.

Sri Sri Ravi Shankar maintained that he did not own any land in the area and that he was made a party to the case for ulterior motives. The Court eventually closed the 2023 PIL in September last year by directing the State to take action against any encroachers in accordance with the law.

However, after the High Court disposed of the 2023 PIL, the Bangalore Metropolitan Task Force (BMTF) registered an FIR suo motu, in which Ravi Shankar was among those accused of land encroachment in Kaggalipura village. Sri Sri Ravi Shankar subsequently moved the present plea to quash this FIR.

During hearings, Sri Sri's counsel highlighted that even in a memo filed by the State's counsel in the PIL, his name had not featured in the list of alleged encroachers. It was also submitted that Sri Sri had not been named in related proceedings initiated by a Land Grabbing Court in 2024.

HC extends interim stay on CJM order to lodge FIR against Sambhal cops

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has extended its interim stay on the Sambhal chief judicial magistrate's order directing registration of FIR against several policemen, including the then Circle Officer Anuj Kumar Chaudhary.

When the matter was taken up on Tuesday, the complainant's counsel filed a counter affidavit in the case. The court then granted time for the petitioner's counsel to file a response on this.

It extended the interim order granted earlier and fixed April 21 as the date for next hearing.

Earlier, Justice Samit Gopal had, after hearing a petition filed by the then Sambhal Circle Officer Anuj Chaudhary, stayed operation of the January 9 order of then chief judicial magistrate directing registration of the FIR.

Apart from Chaudhary, the state Government had also challenged the chief judicial magistrate's order. The court clubbed both the petitions.

The complainant, Yameen, had moved a

petition — filed under Section 173(4) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita — before the then Chief Judicial Magistrate (CJM) Vibhanshu Sudheer.

In his petition, Yameen alleged that his son Alam was selling pape (rusk) and biscuits in his cart near Jama Masjid at Sambhal's Mohalla Kot area at around 8.45 am on November 24, 2024, when the named police officials suddenly opened fire at the crowd "with the intention to kill".

Yameen's petition had named Sambhal Circle Officer Anuj Chaudhary and Sambhal Kotwali in-charge Anuj Kumar Tomar.

In its 11-page order, CJM Sudheer had observed that the police cannot invoke "official duty" shield for criminal acts.

Referring to Supreme Court rulings, the CJM noted that firing upon a person cannot be considered discharge of official duties. Observing that there was prima facie a cognisable offence, the CJM had said that the crime could only be unearthed through a proper investigation.



Guarantee of just compensation cannot be diluted: Supreme Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Stating that the constitutional guarantee of just compensation cannot be diluted, the Supreme Court on Wednesday said solatium and interest in a land acquisition matter cannot be contingent on the magnitude of the financial burden.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Ujjal Bhuyan made the observation while disposing of the National Highway Authority of India's (NHAI) plea seeking review of the apex court's February 4, 2025 verdict — that the 2019 decision of the top court allowing grant of compensation and interest to farmers whose land was acquired under the NHAI Act would apply retrospectively.

The bench said interest payable to the landowners will be according to the land Acquisition Act, which is nine per cent, and not the NHAI Act, which has a five per cent cap.

The court said NHAI sought a review of the decision on the grounds that financial liability from solatium and interest to those whose land was acquired by NHAI was around ₹100 crore as was claimed but around ₹29,000 crore.

The top court in its order today said as far as this contention is concerned, the court made it clear at the outset that even if the corrected financial estimate is taken on record it does not persuade it to revisit the merits of the earlier order.

"The grant of solatium and interest cannot be made contingent upon the magnitude of the financial burden. The constitutional guarantee of just compensation cannot be diluted on that basis. Mere projection of financial liability does not constitute a valid ground for review," the CJI said while pronouncing the order.



The bench, however, said its earlier decisions on the issue require a limited clarification to ensure consistent and equitable understanding of the scope and effect of the judgement.

The top court said it is undisputed that landowners whose lands were acquired under the National Highways Act are entitled to solatium and interest as part of just compensation.

It said that all claims of landowners do not stand on the same footing. In several cases, landowners have pursued different remedies and proceedings, including arbitration and court proceedings, for enhancing compensation or grant of benefits.

"We are of the view that while landowners may be entitled to solatium and interest as a matter of law, they cannot be permitted to reopen concluded claims which have attained finality. The balance between the rights of landowners and the need for certainty in litigation must be maintained. Endless reopening of settled claims cannot be permitted," it said.

On February 23, the top court orally

observed that pre-March 2018 land acquisition cases cannot be reopened for granting compensation with interest to the farmers whose land had been acquired under the NHAI Act.

In 2019, the apex court held that the decision to grant compensation with interest to farmers whose land was acquired under the NHAI Act would apply retrospectively. The NHAI contended that the 2019 judgement imposed a huge financial burden (approximately ₹32,000 crore) and should therefore apply prospectively.

The top court previously rejected this contention, noting that denying such benefits violated Article 14 (right to equality) of the Constitution.

"The cut-off date appears to be of 2008, provided claims were alive then. Pre-2018 matters cannot be reopened. Those matters which were pending in 2008 continue. If someone in the early 2020s filed an application saying they are entitled to parity on the basis of 2008, we can say yes as the solatium but not interest, like in land acquisition matters," the top court had observed.

Will he dictate to me: CJI Surya Kant fumes over litigant's father calling his brother

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Wednesday took umbrage at the conduct of a litigant whose father made a phone call to the CJI's brother objecting to a judicial order regarding minority reservation for a medical post-graduate course.

The matter pertains to one Nikhil Kumar Punia, born into Haryana's Jaat Punia community, seeking a minority reservation after converting to Buddhism in Uttar Pradesh's Subharti Medical College.

On January 28, the Supreme Court, while observing that the plea was a "new type of fraud", had directed an inquiry into the petitioner's minority certificates.

On Wednesday, the CJI was infuriated while referring to the "shocking" incident and



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant

said, "Nobody dares to do this. And you think I will transfer the case because of this? I have dealt with such elements for the last 23 years."

He went on and said, "Now you tell us why we should not initiate criminal contempt against the father of your client. What he (father) has done, should I disclose in

open court? "He calls up my brother and asks him how the Chief Justice of India has passed this order. Will he dictate to me?"

Slamming the conduct, he told the advocate, "You verify it (the conduct). As counsel, you should first consider withdrawing. This is sheer misconduct. Even if he is outside India, I know how to deal with such people."

To this, the advocate apologised.

"I am very sorry, Sir, but I am not aware of all this," he said.

The court adjourned the matter to next week after noting that Haryana had not filed a compliance report regarding the guidelines for issuing minority certificates, including whether general category candidates could get a minority certificate after claiming to convert to Buddhism.

SC grants interim relief to Sameer Wankhede in Cordelia cruise case probe



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday granted interim relief to Indian Revenue Service (IRS) Officer Sameer Wankhede in his plea challenging disciplinary proceedings initiated against him in relation to the 2021 Cordelia cruise drug bust case.

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe was hearing Wankhede's plea challenging the recent Delhi High Court order that overturned the Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT) order quashing all disciplinary proceedings arising out of a chargesheet issued against him in 2025.

The central Government approached the Delhi High Court to challenge the CAT order passed on January 19, quashing the 'Charge Memorandum' issued to Wankhede on August 18, 2025 by the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC).

No coercive action against Meta platforms without hearing: Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday asked the Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) not to take any coercive action against Meta Platforms Inc over any unauthorised listing on Facebook marketplace without giving the US-based social media giant an opportunity to present its stand.

Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav, while dealing with Meta's petition against a CCPA order imposing a ₹10 lakh penalty on it for alleged unauthorised sale and listing of walkie-talkies on the Facebook Marketplace, said the platform cannot be penalised by giving "vague and omnibus" directions.

The senior counsel for Meta said that in compliance with the order, the platform was not permitting any listings for walkie-talkies on the marketplace but objected to the other "omnibus" directions to it, including ensuring that no other product requiring statutory approval/ certification was listed or sold without due approvals.

The counsel for the Centre defended the order and submitted that the CCPA was legally empowered to pass the directions.

"The court, however, finds that the petitioner could not be penalised on account of any vague or omnibus directions which seem to have been issued in paragraph 43(b) (of the order). Unless the



act of the petitioner is clearly in violation of any applicable rules or regulations, the petitioner cannot be penalised," said Justice Kaurav.

"It would mean that before taking any coercive step or any other action, the petitioner would be given due opportunity (of being heard). Paragraph 43(b) stands clarified," the judge stated.

The court granted the petitioner liberty to approach the National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission (NCDRC) with its grievance that the CCPA lacks jurisdiction over it because it is not an e-commerce platform.

The petitioner is granted liberty to raise the issue before the NCDRC by filing an appeal, the court said.

Meta's senior counsel sought liberty from the court to raise objections against the

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Nearly 70,000 cases of Government employees are pending adjudication in the Central Administrative Tribunal, the Lok Sabha was informed on Wednesday.

The Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT) is the competent authority that adjudicates grievances and disputes arising out of the conditions of service of Central and State Government employees.

These pending grievances include cases related to pay, promotion, career progression, pension and similar matters, Union Minister of State for Personnel Jitendra Singh said in a written reply.

"Since its inception in the year 1985, the CAT has received 9,88,738 cases for adjudication, out of which 9,19,157 cases have been dis-

Allahabad HC grants anticipatory bail to Swami Avimuktेश्वaranand

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court on Wednesday granted anticipatory bail to Swami Avimuktेश्वaranand Saraswati and his disciple Mukundanand Brahmachari in a case registered against them under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act.

The order was passed by Justice Jitendra Kumar Sinha on the anticipatory bail applications moved by the seer and his disciple.

However, the court restrained both the first informant and the applicants from making any statements before the media in this regard.

Earlier on February 27, the court had stayed the arrest of Avimuktेश्वaranand, directing that he would not be taken into custody till the pronouncement of the order in the matter related to alleged sexual harassment of minor children and other offences.

The court had also reserved its order after hearing the matter and directed the applicants to cooperate with the investigation.

The case pertains to an FIR lodged at the Jhansi police station in Prayagraj following directions from a POCSO court, alleging sexual exploitation of several 'batuks' (young disciples) by the accused.



Swami Avimuktेश्वaranand

During the last hearing, Justice Sinha had also directed the State Government and the complainant, Ashutosh Pandey alias Ashutosh Brahmachari, to file their replies.

Avimuktेश्वaranand had maintained that the allegations were fabricated, while the complainant had hoped justice would be served after the evidence was submitted in court.

The defence had argued that the complainant has a criminal history and that the seer has been falsely implicated, also claiming that the alleged victims never stayed at his ashram.

The State had opposed the plea on technical grounds, saying it was filed directly in the High Court without first approaching a sessions court.

The seer had even expressed willingness to undergo a narcoanalysis test to establish the truth. He also questioned the validity of medical reports and alleged that the complainant was influencing the case.



posed till January 31, 2026, leaving 69,581 cases under adjudication presently," Singh said. The number of cases instituted, disposed and pending year-wise since the inception of the tribunal are available in the annual report of Department of Personnel and Training, which can be accessed through the link [https://dopt.gov.in/sites/default/files/AR2024-](https://dopt.gov.in/sites/default/files/AR2024-25English.pdf)

25English.pdf, Singh said. To ensure expeditious disposal of all cases, the tribunal has rolled out cloud-based Advance Case Information System comprising several new initiatives, such as mobile applications, SMS facility, online payment, hybrid video conference-based hearing, e-courts set up, scanning and digitisation of all records and e-filing of cases, the minister added.

Facebook Marketplace was subject to and governed by the legal framework for e-commerce.

The petition also claimed the CCPA passed the order in violation of principles of natural justice.

The CCPA compounded its jurisdictional excess by ruling that it violated the intermediary guidelines, which fall within the purview of the Union Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), the plea said.

In its January 1 order, the CCPA also directed Meta to ensure that no walkie-talkies or any other product requiring statutory approval/ certification is listed, hosted, advertised or sold on its platform without full compliance with applicable laws and mandatory disclosures.

It also asked Meta to periodically undertake a self-audit to check deceptive listings and publish a certificate of such self-audit on its website in the public and consumer interest.

Earlier, the CCPA took suo motu cognisance of the large-scale illegal listing and sale of walkie-talkies (personal mobile radios) on e-commerce platforms and imposed monetary penalties on several online marketplaces.

It identified more than 16,970 non-compliant walkie-talkie listings across platforms and issued notices to 13 e-commerce entities, including Amazon, Flipkart, Meesho, JioMart and Meta.



Editor's
TAKE

The changing paradigm of national security

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh's recent remarks underline a profound shift in how nations must understand and safeguard their security

Warfare in the twenty-first century has drastically changed; it is very different from what it was in earlier times. Gone are the days when war meant tanks, aircraft and artillery firing at army positions on the border and soldiers braving it on the frontline. Today the border has stretched everywhere - the whole country is a battlefield, and it is not just about artillery; it has several new dimensions which were hitherto unknown. Cyber attacks, economic blockades, internet disruption and psychological warfare have now taken centre stage. Any country that runs on foreign dependencies is vulnerable. Ironically, a country that is digitally advanced is more prone to outages. This is no science fiction; these are the lessons of the Iran-Israel-US war right now raging in West Asia.

Today, as Rajnath Singh rightly noted, while speaking at a Sainik School function, countries can be destabilised not only through military aggression but also via cyberattacks, economic coercion, information warfare and disruptions in space-based infrastructure. Indeed, the battlefield has expanded, and so must the nation's preparedness. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has already flagged the economic and strategic implications of these developments, calling the situation "worrisome". Economic resilience is now inseparable from national security. The two are intertwined, and a country that aspires to be regional power must take that into account in its defence preparedness while simultaneously improving its military might – ballistic missiles, fighter jets, tanks and so on.

It cannot afford to depend upon imported oil; it cannot depend upon internet servers and cables running through oceans for internet access. It must have its own servers. It has to develop anti-ballistic missile architecture to protect itself from ballistic missiles. The key, therefore, is indigenisation of defence. In this changing scenario, India's preparedness must be assessed across multiple dimensions. On the military front, there is visible progress, but there is a long way to go. The government has prioritised modernisation, with increasing emphasis on indigenous defence production and advanced technologies. Institutions like the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) are playing a pivotal role in strengthening capabilities. Cybersecurity is a big concern, not only in times of war but also in peacetime, and attackers could be sitting next door. Their attack on financial systems, critical infrastructure or communication networks can cripple a nation without a single shot being fired. Similarly, information warfare –through misinformation and narrative manipulation – poses a serious challenge to social cohesion and democratic processes. India has made strides in these areas, but institutional coordination and public awareness still lacks. Equally important is energy security. India must diversify its energy sources, build strategic reserves and invest in resilient infrastructure. Besides, an informed, vigilant and resilient population can act as the first line of defence against national threats, as Rajnath Singh pointed out. We must safeguard systems, institutions and the collective confidence of a nation. And we have to act fast before someone exploits these vulnerabilities.

When climate models fall short of reality

As temperatures surge as early as March, the evidence is unmistakable: India's urban centres are heating faster, retaining heat longer, and exposing millions to risks that existing models and policies are failing to fully capture

PHOTO: PANKAJ KUMAR



EILIA JAFAR

There is a dangerous gap between what climate models are telling policymakers and what is actually unfolding on the ground across India's cities. That gap is not a rounding error. It is a matter of life and death for tens of millions of people, and it is widening with every passing summer.

It is only March, yet soaring temperatures across large parts of India are already testing human endurance, an early warning of what the months ahead may hold. Over the past four decades, India's average surface temperature has already risen by about 1°C. With a large share of its population concentrated in already warm regions, the country faces some of the highest levels of human exposure to extreme heat anywhere in the world.

A landmark study published in the Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences has found that 81 per cent of 104 medium-sized cities across Asia, Africa, the Middle East and the Americas are projected to warm faster than their surrounding rural areas even under a 2°C global warming scenario – the upper limit set by the Paris Agreement. Within this global pattern, India stands in a category of its own.

The urban heat trap

According to the study, Indian cities experience an additional 45 per cent increase in land surface temperature compared to surrounding rural areas under a 2°C global scenario. This pushes expected city warming from about 2.2°C in standard models to roughly 2.6-2.7°C once urban factors are included. In cities such as Patiala in Punjab, urban warming could nearly double regional projections.

Part of the explanation lies in India's climate geography. Monsoonal and humid regions usually warm less than arid areas because evaporation and vegetation help regulate temperatures. Cities replace these natural cooling systems with concrete, asphalt and dense built environments that absorb heat during the day and release it slowly over time.

Urban expansion is intensifying the problem. According to the Lancet Countdown, India's urban greenness declined by around 3.6 per cent between 2015 and 2024, removing natural cooling buffers and making cities more vulnerable to extreme heat.

A public health emergency

Indian cities located at similar latitudes are



EXTREME HEAT IS ALSO BEGINNING TO AFFECT THE ECONOMY. IN 2024, INDIA EXPERIENCED CLOSE TO 20 HEATWAVE DAYS ON AVERAGE. THE RESULT WAS THE LOSS OF NEARLY 247 BILLION LABOUR HOURS, WHICH TRANSLATES INTO AN ESTIMATED ECONOMIC LOSS OF ABOUT \$194 BILLION

The writer is a Humanitarian and Development Professional with more than 20 years of national and international experience

dailypioneer
 @ThePioneer
 The Pioneer

already hotter than many cities elsewhere in the world. Combined with uneven access to water, electricity, cooling infrastructure and air conditioning, this places large sections of India's urban population at disproportionate risk of heat-related illness and mortality.

Extreme heat is also beginning to affect the economy. In 2024, India experienced close to 20 heatwave days on average. The result was the loss of nearly 247 billion labour hours, which translates into an estimated economic loss of about \$194 billion.

The impact is not evenly shared. Workers in the informal economy, such as construction labourers, street vendors and delivery personnel, often have little choice but to continue working outdoors even during the hottest hours of the day. Women face additional risks in many workplaces where poor sanitation facilities discourage regular water intake, increasing the chances of dehydration and heat-related illness.

The night that never cools

Perhaps the most alarming shift is happening after sunset. Over the past decade, very warm nights have increased faster than extremely hot days. Nearly 70 per cent of Indian districts experienced five or more additional very warm nights each summer.

Night-time heat is especially dangerous because it prevents the human body from recovering from daytime stress. Over the past decade, Mumbai recorded around 15 additional very warm nights per summer, Bengaluru 11, while Bhopal and Jaipur saw about seven each. Much of this trend is linked to the urban heat island effect, where heat stored in buildings and roads during the day is released overnight. Rising humidity is compounding the risk. Relative humidity across North India and the Indo-Gangetic Plain has increased by up to 10 per cent in the past decade. Higher humidity raises the heat index – the measure of how hot conditions actually feel – making heat stress more likely

even when temperatures remain constant.

An Ocean on the Boil

While the crisis is most visible in cities, the surrounding oceans are also warming rapidly. A study published in ScienceDirect suggests that the Indian Ocean could warm by 1.7 to 3.8°C per century between 2020 and 2100. In energy terms, this increase is equivalent to adding the heat of one Hiroshima atomic bomb every second for a decade.

The Indian Ocean drives nearly 70 per cent of India's rainfall through the southwest monsoon. Marine heatwave days could rise from roughly 20 days annually today to between 220 and 250 days by the end of the century, threatening fisheries, rainfall stability, cyclone intensity and food security.

Seen in this light, India's current heat preparedness appears inadequate. Many heat action plans at the district and state level rely on projections from global climate models operating at coarse resolution, models that, as the PNAS study demonstrates, fundamentally miss changing urban heat island effects. Tier-2 cities are not equipped to handle the projected scale of heat stress. Community cooling centres, emergency response measures, heat hotlines, public early warning systems and heat buddy networks are interventions that are standard in parts of the developed world but remain sparse or absent across much of India.

The district-level risk analysis points to the need for a far more layered response. Heat action plans must move beyond simple daytime forecasts to account for warm nights, rising humidity and local vulnerabilities. States should also make fuller use of disaster mitigation funds to build cooling shelters, expand green spaces and strengthen early warning systems. Measures such as heat insurance for vulnerable workers and a national repository of heat action plans could further improve preparedness and coordination.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

In times of global conflict, turn to faith not fear



AJIT KUMAR BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

People all over the world are getting quite disturbed. Lives are being lost, precious resources are being squandered and supply lines are getting disrupted. There is chaos and lots of speculation is going on about the future. There is fear about personal safety and well-being.

Let me first clarify that whatever is happening is destined. How else did famous soothsayers like Nostradamus and Baba Vanga foresee events centuries later? Why? Because what we do today results in fruit later. Nothing happens by chance. There is group destiny; people of a country contribute to a future happening.

Let me restrict this article to how these wars are affecting us and what we can do about it. There are two classes of people. One is the common man – a non-devotee. The other is a devotee of God. Let me take up the common



man first. Throughout his life, he will continue to get what he deserves, that is: "What you sow is what you reap." All rewards and punishments are destined. Others can only be mediums for helping or harming, as ordained. No one can harm unless some suffering is due. Therefore, the thought that anything can happen at any time must be dismissed.

The other class of devotees is well placed. God is involved in their lives. Only God has the power to change or give relief from what is destined. He becomes 'karta' (doer) in the lives of devotees. To understand this phenomenon, we must know how something gets done or happens. Lord Krishna has explained in the Bhagavad-Gita: "The place of action and the doer and many different kinds of instruments and many different efforts and

the fifth in this connection is providence only." (18.14) The place of action or circumstances is where and how we are presently placed. The second is karta in our life, whether God or material nature (the Divine Authority), which works under the superintendence of God (9.10). They only reward or punish as destined. We, souls, make this choice; devotees choose or qualify for God being the doer in their lives.

The third is the different instruments possessed by us, like our abilities. The fourth is the different efforts made by us. And the last is what is destined. Left with only two out of five choices, we should make our best efforts in any circumstances and take shelter of God in right earnest. Then God will begin to guide and help; no one is excluded. Wars will go on, as they always do, this world being duhkhalaya (place of misery) (8.15). But we will be under the protection of the Almighty. He will help us to overcome whatever challenges these wars throw at us (18.58); God has promised this to entire humanity. Therefore, let us not fear or panic about these wars; just focus on what best we can do to help ourselves, and remain in the shelter of God. We will do fine. This is God's creation; He is in control.

The writer is a spiritual teacher

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Scheduled caste status debate

The Supreme Court's recent judgment limiting Scheduled Caste (SC) status to individuals adhering to Hinduism, Sikhism or Buddhism invites reflection through the prism of constitutional principles. The Court's reasoning aligns with historical legislative frameworks that recognised caste-based disadvantage primarily within these religious contexts. Legally, this interpretation ensures clarity, consistency and adherence to statutory provisions, thereby upholding the rule of law. Yet constitutional morality, under Articles 14 and 15, requires the State to protect historically marginalised communities and promote substantive equality. Evidence shows caste discrimination often continues even after religious conversion, so restricting SC status solely on religion may conflict with the Constitution's broader commitment to social justice and equality.

A balanced view recognises that while the judgment follows statutory and historical frameworks, a religion-centric approach may not fully achieve constitutional goals. Policymakers should reconcile legal interpretation with the Constitution's broader commitment to protecting disadvantaged groups irrespective of religion.

AC VINEETH KUMAR | KERALA

Reservations should not be misused

The government has provided ample relaxations and access to welfare schemes to Scheduled Castes in order to raise their standards of living, uplift them and bring social equity. There was a time when Scheduled Castes were deprived of basic rights and had to face social discrimination, oppression, unfair treatment and status disparity. Rights to education, jobs, participation in social gatherings and the benefits of government schemes were not easily available to them.

Keeping in mind their basic rights, the need to end historical discrimination and to grant them constitutional protection, the government provided reservations in jobs, education and access to many welfare schemes. However, with changing trends, some people change their religion on the pretext of faith, interfaith marriages or to seek benefits, which amounts to misuse of their status.

The top court's decision to cancel Scheduled Caste status after religious conversion is therefore a welcome move to prevent misuse of constitutional provisions and government welfare schemes. Such steps will ensure that benefits reach those who genuinely need social and economic support.

ABHILASHA GUPTA | MOHALI

Fragile peace in West Asia

Five days is a short pause in the ever-changing theatre of conflict in West Asia. The entire world is waiting with bated breath for this war to end. More than 2,000 people have been killed since the beginning of the US-Israel attack on Iran. Despite back-channel peace negotiations, the war continues to rage on multiple fronts.

The current situation is very fragile, as the United States has shown optimism about negotiations. Donald Trump has said that his Middle East envoy Steve Witkoff and close aide Jared Kushner are talking to a top Iranian official, but Iran has outright denied the existence of formal talks.

The war's global fallout has seen the price of oil and gas rise sharply since last month, and the current oil crisis is being compared to the oil shocks of 1973 and 1979.

To convert this brief ceasefire into lasting peace, both nations will have to ensure minimal violations and sustained diplomatic engagement through mediators.

The core issue of the conflict – Iran's nuclear programme – must be handled with a balanced and sensitive approach.

BAL GOVIND | NOIDA

PIC TALK



A squirrel feeds on a flower bud while perched on a tree branch on a sunny day.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



www.dailypioneer.com

facebook.com/dailypioneer @TheDailyPioneer
 instagram.com/dailypioneer linkedin.com/in/The Pioneer

UNIFORM CIVIL CODE NEEDS DEBATE, NOT LEGISLATIVE HURRY

Gujarat's tabling of the Uniform Civil Code Bill makes it only the second state, after Uttarakhand, to move this far on what has long been more of a political promise than a legislative reality.

The intent behind the Bill – equal civil rights regardless of religion, stronger protections for women, and legal recognition for children born outside marriage – is genuinely worth supporting. On these counts, the legislation deserves a fair and serious hearing.

That said, two provisions in particular warrant careful debate before the Bill is passed in its current form. The first is the mandatory registration of live-in relationships, with non-compliance attracting up to three months in prison.

Whatever one thinks of the underlying policy, criminalising a private domestic arrangement is a serious step, and the proportionality of that penalty needs justification. The Supreme Court has repeatedly recognised the right to live together as a fundamental freedom. Regulation is one thing; imprisonment for failing to file a form is quite another.

The second concern is procedural. A 201-page Bill, drafted on the basis of a committee report submitted barely a week ago, is being debated in the closing hours of a budget session. Legislation affecting personal laws deserves thorough scrutiny, not legislative haste.

M BARATHI | BENGALURU

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.



Subcontinent's Muslims: Time to reflect on borrowed identity

The United States, the mastermind behind the chaos, remains distant and secure. The war zone narrows to a fierce conflict between two warring Islamic groups, Sunni and Shia sects, traditionally known for their internal sectarian violence. On both sides, those suffering and dying are Muslims, while the rest of the world also feels the fallout to varying degrees



BALBIR
PUNJ

For the first time in recent history, Muslims across the Indian subcontinent are confused about who their true enemy is amid the ongoing Middle East conflict. Many see Islamic Iran, the symbolic Casablanca, as under attack by two 'kafir' enemies — the US and Israel. But the situation becomes more complex as Iran retaliates not only against Israel but also against US allies, the Gulf countries, many of which are Muslim and home to over 15 million Muslims from India, Bangladesh and Pakistan.

The United States, the mastermind behind the chaos, remains distant and secure. The war zone narrows to a fierce conflict between two warring Islamic groups, Sunni and Shia sects, traditionally known for their internal sectarian violence. On both sides, those suffering and dying are Muslims, while the rest of the world also feels the fallout to varying degrees.

It is a tough dilemma for Muslims in the subcontinent. They do not know how or against whom they should vent their anger or frustration. Usually in the past, in such tense situations, it was the next-door Hindu. When the Ottoman Caliphate collapsed, Indian Muslims targeted hapless Hindus, went on a killing spree, raped their women and burned their houses. History records that mayhem as the Moplah riots.

Notably, Maulana Abul Kalam Azad issued the 'Hijrat ka Fatwa' in 1920 during this movement, calling for migration from India, a non-Islamic country, to Afghanistan, an Islamic one. Of course, this plan fell through because Afghanistan refused to be a part of it.

This episode highlighted a key aspect of identity formation: the allegiance of subcontinent Muslims that extended beyond territorial boundaries. It is a fruitless pursuit of Ummah — a chimera of a global Islamic collective — that transcends national borders.

In Kashmir's Shia pockets, youth moving door-to-door to collect cash, gold and utensils for victims of a distant West Asian conflict is being hailed as compassion. But strip



THE OBJECTION
RAISED BY MANY
WAS NOT TO THE
GATHERING
ITSELF, BUT TO
THE REPORTED
CONSUMPTION OF
CHICKEN BY
MUSLIM YOUTHS
AND THE
DISPOSAL OF
LEFTOVERS INTO
THE RIVER

The writer is an eminent columnist, former Chairman of the Indian Institute of Mass Communication (IIMC), and the author of 'Tryst with Ayodhya: Decolonisation of India' and 'Narrative ka Mayajaal'

dailypioneer
@balbirpunj
The Pioneer

away the sentimentality, and an uncomfortable question stares us in the face: why is this empathy so geographically and ideologically selective?

Where does this zeal disappear when it comes to the brutal realities closer home? Why no such mobilisation for the victims of the Pakistan-Afghanistan conflict, where Muslims are killed in large numbers? Why no door-to-door collections for persecuted Hindus in Bangladesh?

Recently, Hindu youth Tarun, a Dalit, was lynched by a Muslim mob in Delhi's Uttam Nagar over colours and water spilt during Holi. There was hardly any outrage. Is suffering less worthy of solidarity if it does not fit a preferred narrative?

Most Muslims of the subcontinent continue to look up to West Asian Islamic countries, particularly Saudi Arabia, for guidance, especially in matters relating to faith. According to Mohammed bin Salman's (MBS) 2018 interview, the de facto ruler of Saudi Arabia, "Investments in mosques and madrassas overseas were rooted in the Cold War, when allies asked Saudi Arabia to use its resources (Wahhabism) to prevent inroads in Muslim countries by the Soviet Union."

MBS's revelation is shocking and should prompt Muslims in the subcontinent to reflect. The so-called 'authentic' version of Islam they passionately followed was vetted by the US to serve its geopolitical interests. One wonders how many fedayeen this US-inspired Islamic network produced and how many innocent lives it claimed. Those who believed they were killing or blowing themselves up for Islam were - including many in the subcontinent - in fact dying for the American cause.

Meanwhile, the Arab world itself is undergoing a transformation. Under the leadership of MBS, Saudi Arabia has embarked on a series of reforms aimed at reshaping its social and economic order.

In contrast, on the Indian subcontinent, many Muslims still find themselves stuck in the past, holding on to a colonised mindset. They look down on pre-Islamic civilisations by converted Muslims in the subcontinent is not inherent to Islam. Countries like Indonesia and Malaysia illustrate this clearly.

Former Pakistani High Commissioner to India, Abdul Basit, made shocking

remarks on a Pakistani TV show, claiming, "If America attacks Pakistan, we have to attack India, Mumbai, New Delhi, without a second thought. We will not leave it; we will see what happens later." This statement came in response to US Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard's warning about Pakistan's missile programme.

Such words are fuelled by pure hatred and irrationality, reflecting a deep-seated resentment among some Muslims in the subcontinent against their pre-Islamic civilisation.

This contradiction is not merely theological; it is civilisational. It reflects a deeper intellectual confusion that is neither abstract nor distant. Consider the recent episode in Varanasi, where an Islamic iftar gathering was organised on the banks of the Ganga.

The objection raised by many was not to the gathering itself, but to the reported consumption of chicken by Muslim youths and the disposal of leftovers into the river. Trivialising such concerns, as sections of the political class hastily did, is to misunderstand the civilisational grammar of India. Some commentators asked: by that logic, should the immer-

sion of ashes, cremation ghats along the river, or even carnivorous aquatic life also be considered problematic?

The Ganga is not just a river. It is, in the Hindu worldview, a sacred being — revered, worshipped and deeply linked with life, death and Moksha (liberation). Some asked: what "law" had been broken? Stretch this logic a bit further. Should one host a pork party close to a mosque and share it on social media to rub it in? It may be within the law, but it is surely an insensitive move, a deliberate provocation with the potential to tear communal harmony apart.

Here is a historical reference that emphasises this point. The 1980 Moradabad riots started on 13 August, Eid-ul-Fitr, when a stray pig accidentally entered an Eidgah — an incident that ignited widespread unrest and loss of life and property, disrupting life for nearly nine months.

The depth of outrage in that instance was neither dismissed nor rationalised away. The contrast with contemporary responses is difficult to ignore. The roots of this imbalance, however, lie not in isolated incidents but in a particular historical consciousness.

The distinguished Nobel laureate VS Naipaul captured this with remarkable clarity in his essay Our Universal Civilization:

"I was soon to discover that no colonisation had been so thorough as the colonisation that had come with the Arab faith. Colonised or defeated peoples can begin to distrust themselves. In the Muslim countries I am talking about, this distrust had all the force of religion. It was an article of the Arab faith that everything before the faith was wrong, misguided, heretical; there was no room in the heart or mind of these believers for their pre-Mohammedan past."

Naipaul's observation is difficult to dismiss. It points to a psychological rupture — a distancing from pre-existing cultural memory — that has shaped identity in many post-conquest societies. In the Indian subcontinent, this rupture has been particularly pronounced.

Maybe it is time for the subcontinent's Muslims to reflect — will they embrace the vibrant culture and traditions of their homeland while remaining believers, or continue to be held captive by a colonial mindset chasing the elusive dream of Ummah, a concept that often leads them to a dead end?

Beyond CSR: Mining regions need environmental health systems



SAHIL
PARMAR



SHREYA
ANJALI

India's mining belts, from Dhanbad's coalfields to Korba's industrial clusters and Angul-Talcher's coal complex, have long epitomised the country's development trajectory: abundant energy, industrial growth and economic momentum. Yet behind this narrative lies a persistent environmental health challenge for communities living around mines and power plants. Development indicators may rise, but health indicators in these regions often lag, shaped by chronic exposure to polluted air, contaminated water and toxic metals.

India's energy transition is beginning to shift this landscape. But the health consequences of extraction and combustion remain largely absent from policy discussions. Mining regions require not just corporate social responsibility (CSR) interventions but systematic environmental health protection embedded in public governance.

A shifting energy landscape

India's energy mix is gradually changing. Renewable energy capacity, particularly solar and wind, has expanded rapidly in recent years.

Recent analyses suggest that coal-fired power generation in India declined by about 3 per cent in 2025 compared with the previous year, marking the first such decline in five years. Yet coal remains the backbone of India's electricity system, accounting for around 70 per cent of electricity generation, according to data from the International Energy Agency.

Even under optimistic transition scenarios, coal will remain a significant component of India's energy architecture for decades. This means the environmental and health implications of mining and combustion will continue to affect communities in coal-bearing regions.

The environmental health burden

Mining and coal-based power generation release pollutants, including fine particulate matter (PM_{2.5}), sulphur dioxide, nitrogen oxides and heavy metals such as mercury, arsenic and lead. Coal extraction and blasting generate large



volumes of dust, while coal transport and fly ash disposal add to environmental contamination.

The health consequences of these exposures are substantial. According to the Global Burden of Disease study, air pollution contributes to around 1.6-1.7 million deaths annually in India, making it one of the country's leading health risks.

Heavy metal exposure compounds the problem. Coal and fly ash contain toxic elements, including lead, that can accumulate in soil, groundwater and food systems around mining and power plant sites.

Lead exposure is particularly concerning. The World Health Organization notes that "there is no safe level of exposure to lead" and estimates that lead exposure contributed to more than 1.5 million deaths globally in 2021. Children are especially vulnerable: the UNICEF-Pure Earth report The Toxic Truth estimates that around 800 million children worldwide have blood lead levels above 5 µg/dL, a threshold associated with measurable cognitive harm.

Yet routine environmental health surveillance, such as biomonitoring for toxic exposures, remains limited in many mining districts.

Why CSR is not enough

In most mining regions, environmental and health interventions are delivered primarily through CSR programmes funded by mining companies.

These initiatives often support health camps, ambulances, drinking water systems or local infrastructure improvements. While valuable, they are rarely designed to address long-term environmental health risks.

CSR programmes face several structural limitations.

First, they lack continuity, as projects often depend on corporate priorities rather than sustained public health objectives.

Second, they rarely measure exposure reduction or health outcomes, making it difficult to assess whether pollution-related risks are actually declining.

Third, they operate outside the public health system, meaning data generated through CSR initiatives rarely feeds into district health surveillance or environmental monitoring frameworks.

In effect, CSR tends to address symptoms rather than underlying environmental determinants of health.

Building environmental health systems

Protecting communities in mining districts requires a systemic environmental health framework integrated into existing governance structures.

Several steps are critical.

- Routine biomonitoring: District health systems should incorporate periodic testing for environmental exposures, such as blood lead levels in children and pregnant women in high-risk areas.
- Public environmental data: Air quality, water contamination and soil pollution data should be publicly accessible at district or block levels to enable transparency and accountability.
- Health-sensitive infrastructure: Schools and healthcare facilities in mining areas should include dust control measures, safe drinking water systems and green buffers as part of standard planning.
- Independent monitoring: Post-clearance monitoring of mines and thermal plants should involve independent institutions and incorporate health impact assessments, not just emission data.
- Environmental remediation: Governments must invest in soil restoration, groundwater protection and landscape rehabilitation in degraded mining areas.

Development must include health

India's energy transition offers an opportunity to rethink governance in mining regions. Coal will remain part of the country's energy system for decades, but communities living in these areas should not bear disproportionate environmental and health risks.

Development cannot be measured only in megawatts of electricity or tonnes of coal extracted. It must also be measured in the health and well-being of the communities that sustain the country's energy economy.

Mining towns deserve more than CSR programmes. They need robust environmental health systems that prevent exposure, monitor risks and protect communities over the long term.

The authors are public health professionals at Pahlia India Foundation

dailypioneer
@TheDailyPioneer
dailypioneer

Sustainability is no longer a sideshow, it is the system



SHARMILA
DAS

There was a time not very long ago when sustainability lived quietly in the back pages of annual reports, a well-meaning paragraph tucked between corporate social responsibility and a photograph of someone planting a sapling in a company T-shirt. It was polite, photogenic, and, if we are honest, often peripheral. Today, that quiet paragraph has moved to the boardroom. Not as a gesture, but as a necessity. What is unfolding across industries is not just a shift in language, but a deeper transformation — from compliance to commitment, from reputation to resilience. Because sustainability is no longer about saving the planet in some distant, abstract future; it is about preserving the viability of business itself.

For years, doing what was required was considered enough. Regulations were met, disclosures filed, and reports published. This age of compliance did create progress, standards improved and awareness grew — but it also created a ceiling. Once the box was ticked, the incentive to go further often faded. Sustainability, in many cases, became a carefully curated narrative: a renewable energy announcement here, a recycled-paper report there; each meaningful, but not always connected to how a business truly functioned.

That gap between narrative and reality has become harder to sustain. Scrutiny has sharpened. Consumers, investors and employees alike are asking more informed questions, looking beyond glossy claims into supply chains, sourcing practices and long-term impact. In this environment, the distinction between sustainability as public relations and sustainability as systems change has quietly, but decisively, come into focus.

The former is episodic, campaign-driven and often reactive. The latter is far less visible, but far more consequential. It requires rethinking how products are designed, how materials are sourced, how energy is used and what happens when a product reaches the end of its life. It asks uncomfortable questions: Can this be made differently? Should it be made at all? And while this work rarely lends itself to headlines, it is where credibility is earned.

Nowhere is this shift more evident than in procurement, long considered a purely functional aspect of business. Today, it is emerging as one of the most powerful levers for change. Decisions are no longer driven by cost, quality and timelines alone; impact has become a fourth, non-

negotiable dimension. Suppliers are being evaluated not just on what they deliver, but on how they deliver it — on their carbon footprint, water use, labour practices and waste management.

Sustainability is No Longer a Sideshow. It is the System This is not simply an ethical evolution; it is a strategic one. Since much of a company's environmental and social footprint lies within its supply chain, procurement is where commitments are either realised or diluted. Increasingly, it is turning transactions into dialogues, requiring transparency, collaboration and a rethinking of long-held processes. That demand for transparency has given rise to another defining feature: traceability. "Trust us" is no longer sufficient; stakeholders want to see where materials come from, who processed them and under what conditions. This level of visibility is becoming essential not only for accountability, but for resilience in an increasingly complex world.

Alongside this, certifications have multiplied, offering a shorthand for trust in a crowded landscape. They play an important role, but not all certifications carry the same rigour. Increasingly, stakeholders are looking beyond the label to the substance beneath it: the data, the methodology and the measurable outcomes. A certificate may open the door, but credibility invites people to stay.

Perhaps the most profound shift lies in how products themselves are being imagined. The traditional linear model - create, use, dispose — is giving way to life cycle thinking, where every stage is considered from the outset.

And yet, the true catalyst remains human. Sustainability is shaped by decisions made every day, and culture determines whether it is an obligation or a way of operating.

Organisations that are making this transition successfully share one trait: sustainability is not an add-on, but part of how success itself is defined.

We are at a moment of both reckoning and possibility. Businesses are rethinking models, investors are recalibrating priorities and consumers are using their voice with increasing clarity. The journey from compliance to commitment is far from complete. There will be missteps and inconsistencies, but the direction is clear. Sustainability is no longer a peripheral conversation. It is shaping how value is created, how risk is managed and how success is measured. It is, quite simply, becoming the system.

The writer is a trained Sivananda Yoga teacher

dailypioneer
@TheDailyPioneer
dailypioneer

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

BLASÉ CAPITAL

‘BART’ OF WAR

There is something about the ‘Orange Man’ who keeps changing his colours, tunes, aims, actions, and decisions faster than the trajectories of the sun, moon, planets, stars, and galaxies. For some, his character is evolving, and dissolving into that of the famous cartoon character, Bart Simpson, who is “mischievous, rebellious, misunderstood, disruptive, and ‘potentially dangerous.’” Yet another description: “His penchant for shocking others originates... back to before he was born.... Bart is a notorious prankster... and his pranks are elaborately complex, but can lead to unfortunate consequences.... His actions and speech frequently show considerable mental agility, street-smarts, and understanding.”

Like it or not, believe it or not, these, and other descriptions and explanations fit perfectly with Donald Trump, the US president. Yet, his several-split personality, or his amazing ability to depict different variations of his so-called personality, which has astounded and amazed many, has gone in for another not-much-needed change. According to a media report, he has emerged as ‘Don Tzu,’ or “a portmanteau of Donald Trump and Sun Tzu (ancient writer of the famous book, The Art of War).” Phrases such as ‘Let your plans be dark,’ or ‘In the midst of chaos, there is also opportunity,’ have new meanings.

From the ‘I did not do it,’ and ‘Eat my shorts’ catch-phrases, attributed to Bart, Don Tzu’s new mantra and dictums that were turned into popular social media memes include ‘If you do not know what you are doing, neither does your enemy,’ or ‘You cannot lose if you do not have a goal.’ The war on Iran amply proves the existence of the new Don Tzu, or the ‘Bart of War,’ as depicted by Trump. Sun Tzu rightly said that warfare is based on deception. But he added that when one can attack, one must seem inactive. The Don believes in saying everything upfront, then doing what he said, and later trying to backtrack.

Possibly, all is not lost on the modern Sun Tzu. He has realised that when you surround an enemy, one must leave an outlet free, and not press a desperate foe too hard. But Trump wanted to force Iran into submission. He did not wish to keep an outlet free. When the war dragged on, he tried to free the Strait of Hormuz by issuing an ultimatum, and then giving a five-day reprieve. The peace talks that he talks about may be a strategic move to open one of the closed outlets. Trump needs to get out of the war he never wanted to get out of.

Look at another paradox. Now, the entire focus is to open the Strait of Hormuz to ease global crude oil supplies, and supply chains for other crucial commodities. The war will end if Iran agrees to a truce that allows shipments from the Middle East to Asia. Indeed, Trump has said the same, keep the Strait open, and America will stop the bombings, or at least not attack sensitive energy assets like power plants. As one of the comments on social media reiterates, no one remembers that the Strait of Hormuz was open before the war. How did one go from ending Iran’s current existence to open what was already open?

Of course, the wise warrior, as Sun Tzu said, avoids a battle. This was indeed the case with Trump, who went around extinguishing ‘small global fires’ that had erupted across the world, and claimed to have stopped several global wars. He wanted a Nobel Peace Prize for it. When he was disregarded, he went seeking wars all over the world. He tried when he warned that he would annex Greenland. He tried when he whisked away the Venezuelan president, and his wife. He tried when he earlier bombed Iran, but only for a few hours.

Finally, Trump changed track, and went headlong to seek, start, and stoke a war that has almost turned into a miniature version of World War III. But he embraced another edict from the book, The Art of War. He kept the enemy confused, as Sun Tzu advised, so that the enemy could not fathom the real intent. Trump changed his objectives, as he changed his tactics, as the days turned into nights, and nights into day. A clever fighter is not the one who wins but wins with ease. Trump has made it tougher as the days went by, nearing impossibility.

As the media report states, “The reality is that this war has slipped out of Trump’s control, if he ever had any to begin with. It will be neither quick nor decisive, like his intervention in Venezuela, nor easy to walk away from by declaring victory where there objectively is none, as Trump did last year after the US bombed the Houthis in Yemen, and some militia in Nigeria.” But it is not easy to write him off easily. He can still pull rabbits out of the hats, even if they are not the rabbits that he intended to, or the hats belong to someone else.

Remember what he did with India and Pakistan? Remember what he almost did with Russia and Ukraine? Remember how he stepped away from Greenland? Maybe he will target Cuba to take the heat off Iran.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | MARCH 26, 2026

BUSINESS

10

Businesses, private jobs decline

Economic sentiments dip in the US due to Middle-East tensions

Economies across the world, especially those in the Middle East, Asia, and Europe, take a beating due to the US-Israel-Iran war, which is on for nearly three weeks. Now, there is bad news from the extreme west, America. The US, which was supposedly the most resilient economy that was able to withstand the Gulf shocks, is for a rude sock, a sucker-punch in the face. The latest survey-based findings show that business activity in America is down to an 11-month low in March 2026. It seems that the entire global economy is in for a spin.

“The flash PMI (Purchasing Managers’ Index) survey data... signal... slower growth... following the outbreak of war in the Middle East. Companies are reporting a hit to demand from the additional uncertainty, and cost-of-living impact generated by the conflict,” warned Chris Williamson, chief business economist, S&P Global Market Intelligence, which conducts the regular surveys across the world. The US Composite PMI Output Index, which tracks manufacturing and services, was down at 51.4 in March, lower than 51.9 in February, and the lowest level since April 2025. It declined for the second consecutive month, though a PMI above 50 is healthy for the private sector.

However, unlike India, where the PMI index for March 2026 is down largely due to the expectations in manufacturing, the opposite was true in the US. In the latter case, the flash PMI for services declined from 51.7 in February to 51.1 in March, even as manufacturing improved from 51.6 to 52.4 during the same period. This has confounded experts, who expected the PMI for manufacturing to dip to 51.3, which would have further pulled down the overall monthly index. Several reasons can account for the manufacturing turnaround. Demand remains firm, and prices have not moved up much due to lower tariffs.

However, the inflationary pressures have begun to bite, and red signals are flashing all over. Williamson called it an “unwelcome combination of slower growth and rising inflation.” The index that measures input prices paid by businesses was up from 60 in February to 63.2 in March, and both services and manufacturing units reported rises that were “widely linked to the war-related spike in energy costs, and tightening supply conditions.” Global crude oil prices have surged by 50 per cent and more in the past 25 days. In the US, the average national gasoline prices were up by nearly \$1 per gallon creating a multiplier effect.

More bad news came on the job front. For the first time in over a year, there was a decline in private-sector employment, as indicated by the PMI survey. There was a deterioration in sentiments. According to a media report, “The findings at face value would suggest persistent labour market weakness, though timely data like weekly claims for unemployment benefits have remained consistent with stable conditions.” The survey’s measure for jobs dropped from 50.4 in February to 49.7 in March, the “first contraction in 13 months.” Services sector was the main culprit, possibly because firms reduced “overheads in the uncertain economic climate” due to the war.

As experts and analysts wait for inflation to raise its ugly head, coupled with economic slowdown and job uncertainty, there will be other repercussions. Last week, the Federal Board left interest rates unchanged, but projected higher inflation and steady unemployment, and indicated a possible single reduction in interest rates this year. “The Fed will therefore need to juggle these intensifying upside risks... against the growing risk of the economy losing growth

momentum, with much depending on the duration of the war, and its impact on energy prices, and global supply chains,” explained Williamson.

A day after the S&P survey, or the next morning in America, the news headlines were blunt and disruptive. The Iranian military dismissed Donald Trump’s claims of peace negotiations, and mocked the US of possibly “negotiating with itself.” The US was expected to deploy 1,000 paratroopers to the Middle East, even as Iran attacked locations in Israel and Gulf nations.

Yet, there was a positive when Iran maintained that “non-hostile vessels” could pass through the crucial Strait of Hormuz. Reports indicate that some ships bound for China, India, and Pakistan have passed through the narrow, but “vial waterway.”

Until February 2026, the US dollar held supreme among global currencies, and strengthened against most of them, especially the Asian ones. However, according to reports, although the dollar edged slightly lower in the month (March 2026), “a high-risk premium for the US dollar exposure persisted.” While the Japanese yen weakened, as did the Indian rupee, the Chinese yuan and Hong Kong dollar remained stable. One can say that the upward surge of the US dollar has stemmed a bit, even as the currency enjoys a safe-haven demand.

There are reports that the US has prepared a 15-point peace plan, and the officials were more confident of Iran’s willingness to end the war. Iran, as mentioned earlier, denied these reports, and indicated that America is possibly more interested to end the war due to economic tensions. “Lower oil prices resulting from the latest developments are negative for the dollar (even if the peace statements are contradicted by fresh Iranian attacks) as the US is a net oil exporter. It also reduces the prospect of the Federal Reserve towards rate rise,” states a report.

Some analysts contend that the Iran conflict “disrupted soft landing hopes, with... warning of 1970s-style stagflation if the conflict persists beyond 30 days.” If the war lasts, the projections are that the global economies will remain stressed for years, and global crude prices are likely to remain high until 2028. “Among the 21 economies that share the euro currency, private sector growth all but stalled this month as companies signalled an increase in delivery times, and expectations of rising costs that they in turn would be trying to pass on,” state some reports. In the US, businesses have passed costs to consumers.

Other G-7 economies fared little better than America or Europe. Business activity, according to S&P PMI indices, grew at the slowest pace in six months, as input costs accelerated. In Japan, it showed the slowest rise in three months. India, which is outside G-7, saw the private-sector growth hit a three-year low in March 2026, as inputs rose the fastest since June 2022, which were passed on to the consumers only partly that led to squeezed corporate margins. India was considered the engine for global growth for the past few years.

A Contrarian Investor

Heading towards a gold trap?

Can we put faith in the bullion, or is it time to leave it alone

Theoretically, and logically, money flows into gold during war times. But in the currency cycle, comments an expert, liquidity is dominant and paramount. As the crisis turned acute, with short-war expectations out the window, investors quickly sold liquid assets like gold to stay in cash. This created a selling spree, spurred by the short positions. Hence, gold is caught between safe-haven trust, and liquidity trap. But this may be a short-term reaction as the currencies take a beating, and keeping money in non-US dollar cash may lead to losses over the next few weeks.

One is not sure what the central banks are doing. They realise that they will need to pump liquidity, or money into the national systems once the war is over. This will be critical to revive the ailing and falling economies. Hence, interest rates will come into focus, especially if growth rates are denied, and inflation soars. In such a scenario, one does not know if the central banks are net buyers of gold, or sellers, or believe in maintaining

their asset bases. This data may be out later, but the central banks’ indecisiveness looms in the air.

Of course, estimates about inflation and interest rates influence the prices of gold. If the prices rise, and central banks are forced to hike rates to bring them under control, bond yields will go up. Hence, the treasury bonds will emerge as another safe-haven, apart from the US dollar. Money will flow from other assets, including equities, gold, real estate, and other commodities, into bonds.

At the same time, if the war lasts, speculative activity will continue in crude oil and petroproducts. Thus, there will be a tendency to leave gold alone for the moment.

When it comes to India, gold has several connotations. The country’s household reserves, which are estimated at \$5 trillion, serve several needs such as “store of value, cultural asset, and emergency liquidity buffer.” Yet, as gold prices have soared since the pandemic, and rose sharply over the past year, Indian gold stepped out of homes,

and into finance firms to act as collateral for loans. Gold loans rose, and families used it to raise cash rather than use limited cash to buy gold. Indeed, both the processes happened, which depended on the mindset.

Another subplot is the purchase of gold in the black market. Even those Indians, who wish to accumulate the yellow metal, especially, if they purchased earlier, and saw huge paper profits, are buying from the illegal markets. They believe in paying a bit less to buy uncut gold, without any papers, to save on taxes. They do not mind because the price differential, or profit margins effectively remain the same. If legal gold is ₹100, and uncut is ₹90, the profit will be ₹10 if the former goes up to ₹110, and ₹9-10 as the latter will move to ₹99-100, as it will tag the prices of legal gold. The tax savings help.

Finally, we end up with two narratives about the future plot. In one of the endings, gold is not a structural risk, or a long-term risk, and the yellow metal may reassert in higher prices once the situation stabilises. In the alternative ending, the downward pressure on gold may continue, as consumers grapple with liquidity crises, cash shortages, inflation, lower growth, higher joblessness, and lower salary increments. In such a scenario, gold prices will remain depressed.

Yesterday, by mid-afternoon, gold prices were up, and analysts said that the upside was due to value buying, and attractive entry levels. But investors cannot take it for granted that they will break the January 2026 highs immediately. They cannot discount the possibility of higher prices. Gold is not caught up between trust and trap, but between a must-bust, and clap-trap (not claptrap).

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

World shares gain over possible de-escalation of Iran war

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Hong Kong

Oil prices fell more than 5 per cent and world shares gained on Wednesday over the possibility of a de-escalation of the Iran war and negotiations between the United States and Iran. US futures were up 0.9 per cent.

In early European trading, Britain's FTSE 100 rose 1 per cent to 10,072.60. France's CAC 40 was up 1.4 per cent to 7,855.31, while Germany's DAX was 1.6 per cent higher at 22,989.80.

Tokyo's Nikkei 225 was up 2.9 per cent to 53,749.62. South Korea's Kospi gained 1.6 per cent to 5,642.21.

Hong Kong's Hang Seng rose 1.1 per cent to 25,335.95, while the Shanghai Composite index was 1.3 per cent higher at 3,931.84. Labubu doll maker Pop Mart's Hong Kong-listed shares fell 22.5 per cent, after it announced annual revenue for last year that was largely in line with analysts' estimates.

Australia's S&P/ASX 200 climbed 1.9 per cent. Taiwan's Taieix was up 2.5 per cent.

US President Donald



Trump's claims of progress being made from talks with Iran this week and his post-nomement on Monday of a deadline to "obliterate" Iran's power plants over the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz have also fuelled optimism that an end to the Iran war could come soon.

Trump's administration has offered a 15-point ceasefire plan to Iran, but an Iranian military spokesperson

mocked the US' attempt at a ceasefire deal Wednesday.

With the Strait of Hormuz being a key waterway for crude oil and liquefied natural gas transport, oil and gas prices have spiked and fluctuated in recent days.

Oil prices fell again on growing hopes for a de-escalation. Brent crude, the international standard, fell 5.2 per cent to \$94.97 per barrel. It was around \$104 on Tuesday.

Benchmark US crude was down 5.3 per cent early Wednesday to \$87.44 a barrel.

While Iran has denied negotiations were taking place, and attacks in the Middle East continued, Pakistan has offered to host talks between Washington and Tehran. And as Trump raised optimism of a de-escalation of the war, at least 1,000 more American troops

from the 82nd Airborne Division are said to be deployed to the Middle East in the coming days.

On Tuesday, US stocks closed lower. The S&P 500 lost 0.4 per cent to 6,556.37. The Dow Jones Industrial Average edged down 0.2 per cent to 46,124.06, while the Nasdaq composite was 0.8 per cent lower to 21,761.89.

Shares of Estee Lauder sank more than 9 per cent, following confirmation that the US-listed company is in merger talks with Spanish beauty and perfume group Puig.

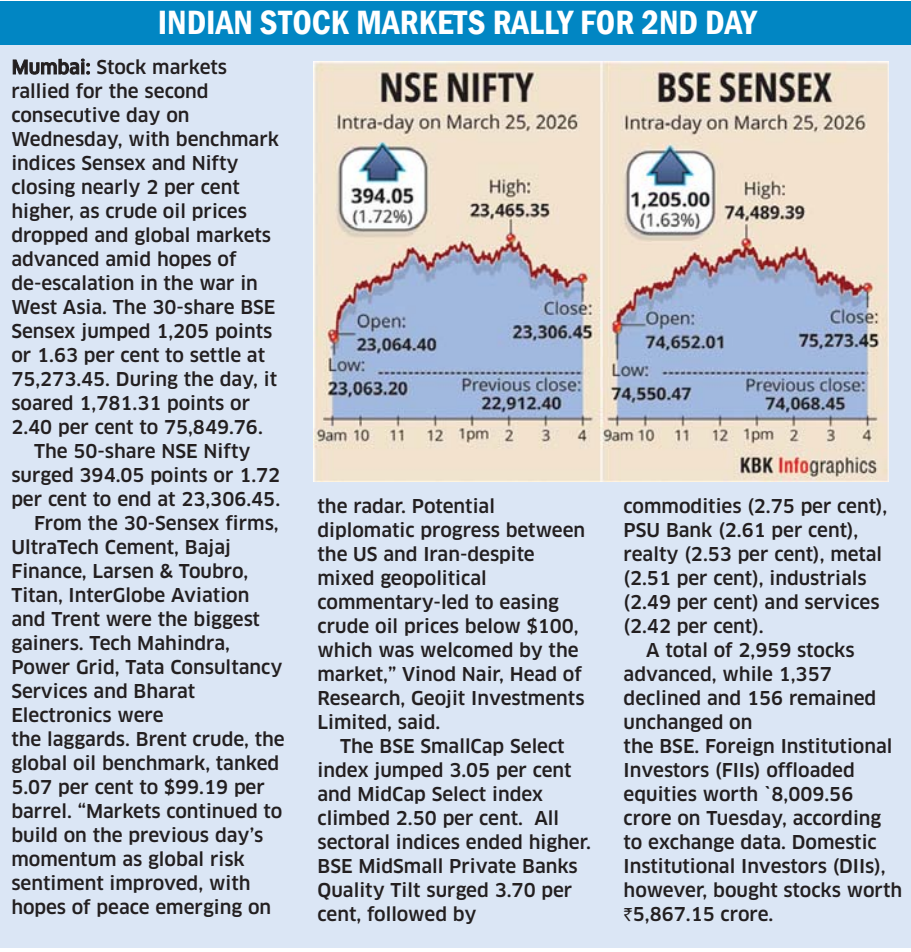
In other dealings early Wednesday, gold prices resumed its rise after falling earlier.

It dropped in part because of rising US Treasury yields over dimming expectations of a Federal Reserve rate cut after the spike in oil prices threatened to fuel global inflation.

The price of gold was up 3.6 per cent early Wednesday to \$4,561.90 per ounce.

It was above \$5,000 earlier this month.

The US dollar was at 158.84 Japanese yen, up from 158.69. The euro was trading at 1.1602, down from \$1.1608.



PAKISTAN

25 injured in

At least 25 people were injured when seven coaches of a train derailed

At least 25 people were injured when seven coaches of a train derailed in Punjab province of Pakistan, officials said on Wednesday. The incident, that took place in Lodhran, some 400 Kms from Lahore, late on Tuesday night, prompted the railway officials to suspend traffic on the affected track. Federal Minister for Railways Hanif Abbasi said that human error and some mechanical issues are most probably the reasons behind the derailment of the Tezgam Express in Lodhran. According to Lodhran Deputy Commissioner Abdul Hafiz, the Karachi-bound Tezgam Express left from Lahore Railway Station on Tuesday evening. "The train derailed when it reached near Adam Wahan Railway Station on Bahawalpur-Lodhran section at 9.30 pm," he said. As many as seven bogies derailed with some passengers trapped in them.

Detour critics

Colombian President Gustavo Petro on Tuesday questioned the use of secondhand planes by the country's armed forces, as officials investigate the crash of a military transport plane that killed dozens of soldiers in southwestern Colombia. "An army cannot defend its own people with crappy gifts," Petro wrote on X in reference to the Hercules CJ-130, which was donated to Colombia by the United States. "They give away whatever is useless to them - and the 'gift' ends up costing more than buying it new."

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

The American military is preparing to deploy around 1,000 troops from the 82nd Airborne Division to the West Asia, a person with knowledge of the plans said.

The troops are to be sent in the coming days, the person said.

The unit is considered the Army's emergency response force and can typically be deployed on short notice. The force would include a battalion of the 1st Brigade Combat Team as well as Major General Brandon Tegtmeier, the division's commander, and division staff, according to the person, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive military plans.

It's the latest addition of American troops after US officials last week said thousands of Marines aboard several Navy ships

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Wednesday briefed Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman about his country's diplomatic efforts to de-escalate tensions in the West Asia situation.

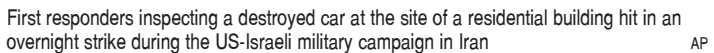
Sharif, in a statement on X, said Pakistan's strong condemnation of the recent attacks on the Kingdom and its unwavering solidarity with Islamabad's unwavering support for Saudi Arabia are unequivocal support for Saudi Arabia in these challenging times.

"I also briefed His Royal Highness Mohammed bin Salman about Pakistan's diplomatic outreach to the Kingdom for regional peace and stability. We remain in close coordination," he said.

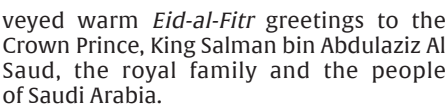
Sharif said that during the call, he reiterated the Kingdom's restraint and its commitment to the urgent need for de-escalation "to prevent further escalation and hostilities. During the conversation,

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Beirut

Lebanon's Foreign Ministry declared Iran's ambassador to Beirut persona non grata on Tuesday, ordering him to leave the country by the end of the week. The decision was the clearest sign yet of deteriorat-



While the Marine units are trained in missions that include supporting US embassies, evacuat-



The *Saudi Press Agency* reported that Sharif “reiterated Pakistan’s full support and commitment to standing firmly with the Kingdom against repeated Iranian attacks threatening its security and sovereignty.” (PTI)

GURDIP SINGH
 ■ Singapore

A State coroner on Wednesday upheld the Singapore Police Coast Guard's (PCG) finding that there was no foul play in the death of Indian singer Zubeen Garg and ruled the death an accidental drowning near an island of the city state in September last year.

Directly addressing a concern raised by Garg's widow regarding the PCG's finding that there was no foul play, State Coroner Adam Nakhoda stated that the PCG had conducted a comprehensive and thorough investigation in this case. Instead, Nakhoda found that Garg's death was "simply due to an unfortunate and tragic accidental drowning" and that no one had forced, coerced or pushed him into the water.

There was also no evidence that the swimmers rescuing him had deliberately held his face underwater, the Channel News Asia reported, citing Nakhoda.

Garg, 52, had been intoxicated, and this likely impaired his judgment in his decisions, said Nakhoda.

This included the removal of his life jacket during his first swim and his "steadfast" refusal to wear it on his second swim despite being told to don the equipment by the yacht captain and other passengers.

Garg drowned in the waters off Lazarus Island on September 19, 2025, a day



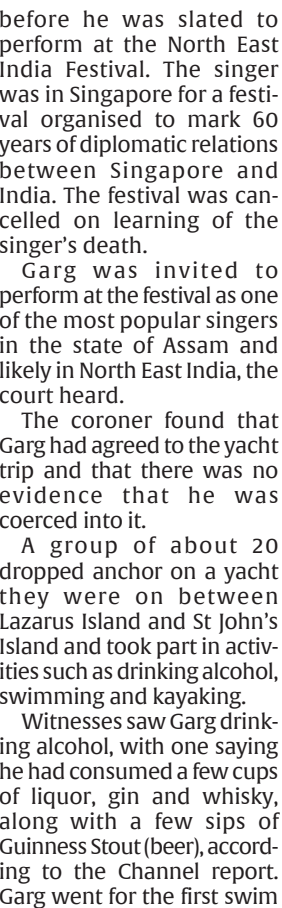
before he was slated to perform at the North East India Festival. The singer was in Singapore for a festival organised to mark 60 years of diplomatic relations between Singapore and India. The festival was cancelled on learning of the singer's death.

Garg was invited to perform at the festival as one of the most popular singers in the state of Assam and likely in North East India, the court heard.

The coroner found that Garg had agreed to the yacht trip and that there was no evidence that he was coerced into it.

A group of about 20 dropped anchor on a yacht they were on between Lazarus Island and St John's Island and took part in activities such as drinking alcohol, swimming and kayaking.

Witnesses saw Garg drinking alcohol, with one saying he had consumed a few cups of liquor, gin and whisky, along with a few sips of Guinness Stout (beer), according to the Channel report. Garg went for the first swim



with a life jacket on, but later removed it and refused another jacket when he went on a second swim towards Lazarus Island.

Members of the group on the yacht shouted for him to be brought back as he was not wearing a life jacket, and Garg turned and was swimming back to the vessel when he went limp in the water. He was rescued back to the yacht and later taken to the hospital, where he died. An autopsy determined the cause of death to be drowning. Coroner Nakhoda found that Garg had been consuming alcohol in the days prior to and on the day of his death.

A toxicology analysis found that Garg had a blood alcohol concentration of 333 milligrams per 100 millilitres of blood, which suggests severe intoxication resulting in impaired coordination and reflexes, the court had previously heard.

For comparison, the legal limit in Singapore is 80 milligrams per 100ml of blood. A high concentration of ethanol was also found in Garg's urine samples.

Garg has a medical history of hypertension and epilepsy, with his last known epileptic episode in 2024, the court heard. While the coroner accepted that it was possible that Garg had suffered an epileptic fit prior to his drowning, the evidence was inconclusive to make a definitive finding on this, said the Channel report.

The court also found there was "nothing untoward" or "sinister" about the invitation extended to Garg to perform at the festival.

The members of the Assam Association in Singapore had gone out of their way to make his visit to Singapore as interesting as possible, the coroner found.

He stressed the coroner's court does not establish whether potential offences were committed.

The question of whether an offence is disclosed is the prerogative of the police prosecutor, following investigations conducted by the police.

"In circumstances where the police have established that there is no foul play involved, and the public prosecutor has concurred with this conclusion, it would be improper for the coroner to make a finding that criminal offences were committed," the Channel had Nakhoda as saying.

No one has been charged in Singapore with any acts or omissions connected with Garg's death, he added. Garg's uncle had attended an earlier hearing and raised concerns the family had over the death, including why Garg entered the sea and whether he had done so of his own free will.

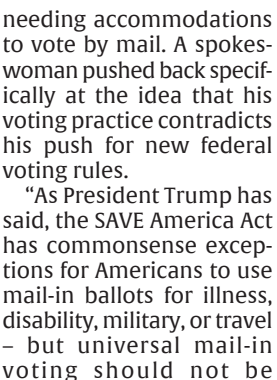
The coroner found that Garg had voluntarily gone on his two swims and was not forced or pushed into the water. He found the swimmers had assisted Garg to the best of their abilities and found no evidence that his face was deliberately held underwater. (PTI)

ASSOCIATED PRESS
 Washington

President Donald Trump has cast another mail ballot in Florida as he continues to publicly bash the voting method as a source of fraud and push Congress to curtail the practice.

Palm Beach County voter records show the president voted by mail in a Tuesday special election for state legislative seats and that his ballot has been counted. Early in-person voting in the contest ran through Sunday, when Trump was still at his south Florida estate. The White House said Tuesday that Trump's ire is at states using universal mail-in voting, not individual instances of voters needing accommodations to vote by mail. A spokeswoman pushed back specifically at the idea that his voting practice contradicts his push for new federal voting rules.

"As President Trump has said, the SAVE America Act has commonsense exceptions for Americans to use mail-in ballots for illness, disability, military, or travel – but universal mail-in voting should not be



NICHOLAS KOMU
Isinya

Kenya's flower industry has reported weekly losses of up to \$1.4 million since the Iran war began, with growers attributing the losses to a decline in demand and shipping disruptions.

The Kenya Flower Council, a private sector organization representing growers and exporters of cut flowers and ornamentals in Kenya, said Tuesday the ongoing conflict has resulted in over \$4.2 million



in losses over the last three weeks.

"We are seeing a reduction in movement, delays in movement of produce, and longer routes, while pricing is extremely high. Last

week, we were at \$5.80 per kilo, which is the highest we've had in the last 10 years," KFC Chief Executive Officer Clement Tulezi told *The Associated Press*. Kenya's horticulture sector, one of its most important industries, is worth over \$800 million annually, according to the Central Bank of Kenya.

At Isinya Flower Farms, located 56 kilometres (34 miles) south of Nairobi, Marketing Manager Anantha Kumar says exports have dropped by more than half. (AP)

[illegible]

PUBLIC NOTICE

Be it known to all that we, Smt. Sarita Gupta (Aadhaar No. 3026 6298 XXXX) and Sh. Kuldeep Kumar Gupta (Aadhaar No. 6667 4943 XXXX), of Vishwas Nagar, Shahdola, East Delhi-110032, hereby declare that we have debarrd and disowned our son Mr. Prince Gupta (Aadhaar No. 8426 1761 XXXX) from all our movable and immovable properties.

It is further declared that the following properties stand in the name and ownership of Smt. Sarita Gupta, which were acquired by her along with her husband Sh. Kuldeep Kumar Gupta, and the said Prince Gupta shall have no right, title, claim or interest whatsoever in the said properties:

1. Property bearing D-1/1, Krishna Handwara, Kirti Market, Krishna Nagar, Delhi - 110017.
2. Flat No. E-1007, 19 Blumeon Homes, Raj Nagar Extension, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh - 201017.

We hereby declare that henceforth we shall have no claim or interest in the said Prince Gupta, and any person dealing with him in any manner shall do so at his or her own risk and consequences.

Shailendra Singh (Advocate)
Ch. No. F-601B,
District Courts, Karkardooma,
Shahdola, Delhi-110032

The Pioneer
Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

S. Sumaiya Masoodi, D/o. Azim
Akhtar, R/o. 389, Basti Hazra
Nizamuddin, New Delhi
10013, have changed my
name from Sumaiya Aleem
Shahzai to Sumaiya Masoodi
after my marriage with Mr.
Mohammad Azhar Masoodi
(24.04.2004) for all future
purposes.

PD(662)/A

NORTHERN RAILWAY INVITATION OF TENDERS THROUGH E-PROCUREMENT SYSTEM			
Tender Notice No. 96/2025-2026		Date : 25.03.2026	
Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-			
S. Tender N. No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01/19260759	BATTERY BOX ASSEMBLY	81 NOS	16.04.26
02/08255249	POWER CABLE, SIZE 2 CORE X 25 Sq. mm	305.5 KM	21.04.26
03/08265168	SUPPLY OF MSDAC 05 DP SYSTEM	117 SET	28.04.26
NOTE -1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No Manual offer will be entertained.			
1009/29			
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE			

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that **Astha Bawa** (hereinafter called the seller's) claims to be owner and in possession of **First Floor of Property No. N-25, Old No. 1619/19, Khalsa No. 301, 302, Dwarikapur, Naveen Shahdara, Illaqa Shahdara, Delhi** (herein after called the said property) by virtue of sale deed dated 26.08.2002 regd. Do. No. 6162 executed by **Vipin Randhawa**, said **Astha Bawa** agreed to sell the said Property to **Ajay Garg** and said **Ajay Garg** has agreed to create a mortgage the said Property in favour of our clients **IDFC First Bank Ltd., Rajendra Place Branch**, any person's having claim against the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/ registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, lien or otherwise howsoever, are hereby intimated to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below **within 7days** from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned and our client shall proceed with the disbursement of loan and subsequent creation of mortgage in respect thereof.

Vishal Diwan (Advocate)
Diwan & Company
Ho.No.2 (LGF), NRI Complex, N.D-19
Mobile No. 9818339999

any person having any type of claim/ interest/ creating mortgage on the said property may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within the time, failing which it shall be presumed that the said person has no claim/ Encumbrances, lien etc. **From N-161, Ground Floor, Salara Tower, Near Yusuf Safai Chowk, Old No. 1619/19, Khalsa No. 301, 302, Dwarikapur, Naveen Shahdara, Delhi**
Contact No: 011-4004633

PUBLIC NOTICE

Be it known to all that we, **Sri (Aadhaar No. 20410083 XXXX) and Smt. (Aadhaar No. 20410083 XXXX)**, residents of Village **Piprahia, Post - Hariharapur, District - Mirzapur, Uttar Pradesh** hereby declare that we have deeded **disanagar** to **Mr. Deepak Kumar Yadav (Aadhaar No. 5682 1267 XXXX)** residing at Flat No. T-301, 131, **Mamlat, Falzabad Road, District - 225003, landmark Mohanpur Police Station, Kaulki, Mohanpur P.O. Sahauki,** and to all our movable and properties.

It is further declared that the following stand in the name and ownership of **Mr. Deepak Kumar Yadav** his husband **Sh. Dhananjay Yadav** said **Deepak Kumar Yadav** shall right, title, claim or interest in the said property.

The property situated at Village **Piprahia, Post - Hariharapur, District - Mirzapur, Uttar Pradesh** 2 Property situated at Village **Ho. No. 2 (LGF), NRI Complex, N.D-19 Mobile No. 9818339999** **Uttar Pradesh - 225003**.

We hereby declare that henceforth we have no concern or relation w/ **Deepak Kumar Yadav**, and any p/son with him in any manner shall do so **own risk and consequences.**

Shalendra Singh (Advocate)
Ch. No. F-601B, District Court, Karkardoma, Shahdara, Delhi

NORTHERN RAILWAY INVITATION OF TENDERS THROUGH E-PROCUREMENT SYSTEM			
Tender Notice No. 96/2025-2026		Date : 25.03.2026	
Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-			
S. Tender N. No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01/19260759	BATTERY BOX ASSEMBLY	81 NOS	16.04.26
02/08255249	POWER CABLE, SIZE 2 CORE X 25 Sq. mm	305.5 KM	21.04.26
03/08265168	SUPPLY OF MSDAC 05 DP SYSTEM	117 SET	28.04.26
NOTE -1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No Manual offer will be entertained.			
1009/29			
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE			

Cuba faces US pressure for leadership change

DANICA COTO
■ San Juan

As US President Donald Trump pushes for change in Cuba's leadership, speculation is mounting about who, if anyone, might replace Cuban President Miguel Diaz-Canel.

As Raul Castro's hand-picked largely figurehead successor in 2018, Diaz-Canel has been the only leader without the last name Castro to govern since the 1959 revolution. He still has two years left in his term, but some experts and a growing number of Cubans doubt he'll make it.

Two Castro cousins have come into focus as potential replacements, experts said.

Oscar Perez-Oliva Fraga - Raul Castro's 55-year-old great nephew - has shot to power since emerging from obscurity several years ago. He became minister of Cuba's influential Ministry of Foreign Trade and Investment in May 2024 and was appointed the island's deputy prime minister in October.

By contrast, Raul Guillermo Rodriguez Castro — Raul Castro's grandson — has never occupied a Government post, having served as his grandfather's bodyguard and later as head of Cuba's equivalent of the US Secret Service.

He has long been known as "Raulito" or "Little Raul" and is new to the spotlight cast on high-ranking



Government officials. But he made news last month when he secretly met on the sidelines of a Caribbean Community summit in St Kitts with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio. At the time, Rubio refused to say

who he was speaking to in the Cuban Government.

"The role Raulito is playing right now is the connection between Raul Castro and whoever is on the US side," said Sebastian Arcos, interim director of the Cuban

Research Institute at Florida International University. "He enjoys the absolute trust of Raul Castro."

But, Arcos and other experts argue, even should someone with the Castro pedigree take the presidency, little is likely to change.

"Party leadership doesn't mean anything in Cuba," Arcos said. "The party is just a hollow facade. The real power resides in the military, under Raul Castro."

The 94-year-old remains at the helm as general, appears at key events and is considered the most powerful person in Cuba, a country subject to more than six decades of absolute rule, first by revolutionary leader Fidel Castro, and then for the

past decade, his younger brother Raul.

And that is unlikely to change. "The most significant thing that we have to consider for the last 30 years in Cuba is the absolute reluctance of this regime to implement serious structural economic reforms," Arcos said. "Asking them for political reforms would be too much."

One Castro cousin is described as a technocrat Perez-Oliva studied electrical engineering before becoming director general of an import company and then business director within Cuba's Mariel Special Development Zone.

That's all the Cuban Government has officially shared on Perez-Oliva. (AP)

Bolsonaro allowed to serve 27-year sentence at home



SOPHIE AUSTIN
■ Sao Paulo

Brazil's former President Jair Bolsonaro received permission Tuesday from a top Brazilian justice to serve his 27-year sentence for a coup attempt at home instead of in prison because of his failing health.

The decision by Supreme Court Justice Alexandre de Moraes followed Bolsonaro's hospitalisation since March 13 for pneumonia, one of several health problems the former leader has faced since he was stabbed by a man in 2018 before he was elected president. Bolsonaro recently was put in intensive care for a few days because of kidney problems and other issues. His doctors did not say when

he would leave the hospital in Brasilia, but his overall condition has improved.

The family of the right-wing leader had been requesting that the court send him home since he was convicted in November. Bolsonaro was transferred from the local federal police headquarters to a larger cell in January.

On Monday, Brazil's Attorney General Paulo Gonet paved the way for Bolsonaro to be put in house imprisonment instead of returning to prison.

Bolsonaro governed between 2019 and 2022. One of his sons, Sen. Flavio Bolsonaro, has said he will run for the presidency in October. Polls show he is in a dead heat with incumbent Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva. (AP)

Bangladesh PM calls 1971 massacre a genocide

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman has termed the genocide of March 25, 1971 as a "pre-planned" massacre and appealed to build a state and society of "equality, human dignity and social justice," in the spirit of the Liberation War.

Calling it as "one of the most disgraceful and brutal days" in the history of Bangladesh, Rahman, in a message on X, also said it is essential to know about the genocide of March 25 to convey the value and significance of independence to the present and future generations. The Pakistani army launched 'Operation Searchlight' on March 25, 1971 to suppress the Bengali people's calls for self-determination in erstwhile East Pakistan, killing over 20,000 people in Dhaka alone.

Officially, three million people were killed in the subsequent nine-month Liberation War. Bangladesh observes Genocide Day to pay homage to the victims.

Rahman's message on Tuesday, on the eve of the Genocide Remembrance Day, said: "The genocide of 25 March was a pre-planned massacre. Why this organised killing spree could not be resisted remains a matter of historical research regarding the visible role of the political leadership of that time."

"Let us all strive to honour the sacrifices of the martyrs by establishing in the state



and society the spirit of the great Liberation War - equality, human dignity and social justice," he added.

Recalling the events of "that dark night," Rahman said the Pakistani occupation forces carried out one of the most heinous genocides in history against the unarmed people of Bangladesh in the name of 'Operation Searchlight'.

"They indiscriminately opened fire on teachers, intellectuals and innocent civilians at various places, including Dhaka University, Pilkhana and Rajarbagh Police Lines, killing many people," the prime minister described.

Calling it as a "pre-planned massacre," and raising questions as to why the organised killing spree could not be resisted at that time, Rahman further said, "On the night of 25 March, the 8th East Bengal Regiment in Chattogram formally initiated armed resistance against the genocide by declaring 'We Revolt'. Through this resistance to genocide, the long nine-month armed Liberation War began."

Belarusian President Lukashenko arrives in North Korea for talks with Kim Tok Hun

DASHA LITVINOVA
■ Seoul

Belarusian President Alexander Lukashenko arrived in North Korea's Capital on Wednesday, where he is expected to hold talks with North Korean leader Kim Jong Un. Lukashenko was greeted at Pyongyang's airport by senior North Korean official Kim Tok Hun, who was appointed vice premier this week, according to Belarusian State news agency Belta.

North Korea's official Korean Central News Agency earlier reported that



North Korea's leader Kim Jong Un and Belarusian President Alexander Lukashenko walking during official meeting ceremony in Pyongyang AP

Lukashenko would make an official visit at Kim's invitation, but did not immediately confirm his arrival.

Lukashenko, who has ruled

Belarus for over three decades with an iron fist, is a close ally of the Kremlin. He allowed Russia to use Belarusian territory as a staging ground for

Moscow's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, and later authorised the deployment of Russian tactical nuclear weapons in Belarus.

Kim has also prioritised Russia in recent years, sending thousands of troops and large quantities of weapons to support President Vladimir Putin's war in Ukraine, while pursuing a more assertive foreign policy aimed at expanding ties with countries that oppose Washington.

During a speech at North Korea's rubber-stamp parliament, Kim accused the United States of global "State terrorism and aggression." (AP)

Shot down 489 Ukrainian drones: Russia

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Moscow

Russian air defences downed 389 incoming Ukrainian drones, Russia's Defence Ministry said Wednesday, in what was the largest reported overnight attack on Russian regions and Crimea since Moscow's forces invaded Ukraine more than four years ago.

The drones were stopped over 13 Russian regions as well as the Crimean Peninsula, which Russia illegally annexed from Ukraine in 2014.

The attack underlined the growing capability of Ukraine's domestically developed and manufac-



tured long-range drones.

It came a day after Russia fired almost 1,000 drones and 34 missiles at civilian areas of Ukraine in the space of 24 hours, extending its usual nighttime barrage into

daylight hours in one of its biggest aerial attacks of the war. At least six people were killed and around 50 people were injured, Ukrainian authorities said. The United Nations cultural organiza-

tion UNESCO on Wednesday said it was "deeply alarmed" by Russia hitting a World Heritage site in the western Ukraine city of Lviv during that bombardment.

The escalation in aerial attacks comes amid a pause in US-mediated talks between delegations from Moscow and Kyiv, as Washington's attention is diverted by the Iran war and as Ukraine anticipates a spring offensive by Russia's bigger army.

Alexander Drozdenko, governor of the Leningrad region north of Moscow, said 56 drones were shot down there, and a fire broke out in the Baltic Sea port of Ust-Luga as the result of Ukraine's attack.

Danish election produces inconclusive result, leaves prime minister's future unclear

KOSTYA MANENKOV/GEIR MOULSON/JAMES BROOKS
■ Copenhagen

Denmark's election ended in an inconclusive result that left the prime minister's future unclear, after a campaign that focused on bread-and-butter issues rather than her handling of the crisis over US President Donald Trump's ambitions toward Greenland.

Official results showed that Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen's centre-left Social Democrats lost ground compared with the last election in 2022, as did her two partners in the outgoing Government. Neither left-leaning nor right-leaning blocs won a majority in parliament. That left experienced Foreign Minister Lars

Lokke Rasmussen, a former prime minister, in the role of kingmaker.

His centrist Moderate party, with 14 lawmakers in the 179-seat parliament, is in a position to determine whether Frederiksen can serve a third term at the helm of the European Union and NATO country.

Frederiksen said that she is ready to stay on as prime minister. "The world is unsettled. There are strong winds around us," she said. "Denmark needs a stable Government, a competent Government. We are ready to take the lead."

Kingmaker calls on rivals to 'come and play with us' Lokke Rasmussen called on rivals on the left and right to climb down from some of the positions they staked out in



Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen speaking to members of her Social Democratic Party in the Danish Parliament in Copenhagen AP

the campaign, and "come and play with us."

Denmark "is a small country of 6 million people in a world of 8 billion, which is in upheaval - and there is war

in Iran, and there is war in Ukraine," he said. He argued that "We are one tribe. We must come together. We must not be divided."

But Defence Minister Troels

Lund Poulsen, the best-placed centre-right challenger to Frederiksen, made clear that he and his Liberal party don't intend to go into Government with her Social Democrats again.

The Social Democrats remained the biggest single party by some distance, but with 21.9 per cent of the vote - well below the 27.5 per cent they took in the 2022 election. The 48-year-old Frederiksen is known for strong support of Ukraine in its defence against Russia's invasion and for a restrictive approach to migration - continuing what has become a tradition in Danish politics.

Frederiksen called the election early Frederiksen called the election in February, several months before she had to. She apparently hoped

that her resolute image in the standoff over Trump's push for control of Greenland, rallying European allies behind Denmark, would help her with voters.

Her support had previously waned as the cost of living rose, something that, along with pensions and a potential wealth tax, has been a prominent campaign issue.

No single party had been expected to come anywhere near winning a majority. Denmark's system of proportional representation typically produces coalition Governments, traditionally made up of several parties from either the "red bloc" on the left or the "blue bloc" on the right, after weeks of negotiations. Frederiksen's outgoing administration was the first in decades to straddle

the left-right divide.

Social Democrat lawmaker Morten Klessen said the outgoing Government had performed well, but that "there's been a lot of trouble in Europe and I think our Government has had a lot of focus about Ukraine and I think we have lost a little bit in domestic votes for that."

He argued that "we need Mette Frederiksen in Europe for solidarity."

Frederiksen herself said she had hoped for a better result, but it was normal for a party seeking a third term to lose ground. She compared Tuesday's result with the 25.9 per cent of the vote her party took in 2019, when she became prime minister. "I have been in charge of this wonderful country for nearly seven years," she said. (AP)

Nurse turned archbishop celebrates leading Church of England

DANICA KIRKA
■ London

A former cancer nurse who became a priest at the age of 40 will be installed as archbishop of Canterbury on Wednesday, publicly celebrating her election as the first woman to lead the Church of England.

Although Sarah Mullally, 63, formally became the archbishop of Canterbury in January, On Wednesday's event marks the beginning of her public ministry as both the head of the Church of England and spiritual leader of the worldwide Anglican Communion. The communion is an association of



independent churches, including the Episcopal Church in the US, that together have more than 100 million members. "I intend to be a shepherd who enables

everyone's ministry and vocation to flourish, whatever our tradition," Mullally said when named last year.

"Today I give thanks for all the women and men ... who

have paved the way for this moment.

And to all the women that have gone before me, thank you for your support and your inspiration." The ceremony will be attended by Prince William, Princess Catherine, UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer and representatives from many of the communion's 42 member churches. Representatives from the Vatican and the Orthodox church will also attend.

In a nod to Mullally's historic appointment, the service is taking place on the Feast of the Annunciation, which marks the moment Mary was told she had been

chosen to be the mother of Jesus. It is a day on which the church says it celebrates "one of the great women of the Bible and thinks about how we can respond to God's call."

The celebration marks a major milestone for the Church of England, which traces its roots to the year 597, when the pope sent St. Augustine to Britain to convert the population to Christianity.

He is now recognised as the first archbishop of Canterbury. The English church broke away from the Roman Catholic Church in the 1530s, during the reign of King Henry VIII. (AP)

UK police arrest two men over arson attack

DASHA LITVINOVA
■ London

British police arrested two men on Wednesday in connection with an arson attack on four ambulances belonging to a Jewish charity, which authorities are investigating as an antisemitic hate crime.

The Metropolitan Police said the two men, aged 45 and 47, were arrested on suspicion of arson with intent to endanger life and both men have been taken to a London police station for questioning. Commander Helen Flanagan, head of Counter Terrorism Policing London,

said the arrests marked "an important breakthrough in the investigation."

But she noted that surveillance camera footage of the incident suggests three people were involved.

Police have not declared the incident to be a terror attack, but are investigating a claim of responsibility by a group with potential links to Iran. The blaze early on Monday morning in Golders Green, a London neighbourhood with a large Jewish population, consumed four ambulances belonging to the volunteer organisation Hatzola Northwest. (AP)

Sri Lanka targets two IMF tranches in one go: Central bank Governor



Nandalal Weerasinghe

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Faced with the external shock of the US and Israel's conflict with Iran, Sri Lanka has been looking forward to clenching two tranches together when the IMF team due here completes its mission, the island nation's central bank Governor Nandalal Weerasinghe said on Wednesday.

An International Monetary Fund (IMF) team will arrive here on Thursday and remain until April 9 to conduct the combined fifth and sixth reviews of Sri Lanka's reform programme supported by the global lender's Extended Fund Facility (EFF).

The two tranches together are expected to release USD 700 million from the USD 2.9 billion bailout in 2023.

"Obviously, situation changes; if outlook is different, we have to discuss what changes are needed," the governor said.

PROSPECT

IBC led to recovery of over ₹4 lakh cr from insolvent firms in last 10 years: Anurag Thakur

The introduction of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) has led to the recovery of over Rs 4 lakh crore in the last decade through the resolution of bankrupt companies, senior BJP MP Anurag Thakur said in the Lok Sabha on Wednesday. Participating in the debate on the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (Amendment) Bill, 2025, Thakur said IBC is not a recovery mechanism but a revival and resurrection of the company. The IBC enacted in 2016 has done a recovery of 50 per cent, while the SARFAESI Act, 2002 (Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest) has done a recovery of 20 per cent, and the Debts Recovery Tribunals have done a recovery of 10 per cent, he said, adding, "This indicates greater efficiency of IBC."

Bank employees, officers demand immediate resolution of PLI impasse



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The United Forum of Bank Unions (UFBU), an umbrella organisation of nine unions, on Wednesday demanded the immediate reversal of the unilateral implementation of the revised performance-linked incentive (PLI) formula.

The revised PLI formula sought to be imposed by the Department of Financial Services (DFS) is viewed by the workforce as an unilateral and divisive departure from the existing settlement-based PLI scheme evolved through bilateral discussions and incorporated in the bipartite settlement/joint note framework, UFBU said in a statement. It further pointed out that the matter is already under conciliation before the office of the Chief Labour Commissioner (Central). In the conciliation pro-

ceedings held on March 9, 2026, the issue of payment of PLI to officers in Scale IV to VII for FY 2024-25 under the existing bipartite settlement/joint note remained under active consideration, with further steps to be taken through conciliation and bilateral discussions, it added. In such a situation, any unilateral implementation by DFS, IBA or individual bank managements during the pendency of conciliation is wholly unacceptable and cannot be reconciled with the requirement of orderly and lawful industrial relations, it said. UFBU, therefore, calls upon the Department of Financial Services, the Indian Banks' Association and the managements of all public sector banks to immediately keep all unilateral steps in abeyance and resolve the matter without delay through dialogue and negotiated settlement, it added.

Commerce Secy meets deputy USTR Joseph Barloon; discusses WTO issues, bilateral trade

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal on Wednesday held a meeting with Deputy US Trade Representative Joseph Barloon, and discussed issues related to the WTO's ministerial conference and ways to further expand bilateral trade ties. The meeting was held in Yaounde, the capital city of Cameroon. Both are in the African nation for the 14th ministerial conference (MC14)

of the World Trade Organisation (WTO). The four-day meet will start on March 26. They had detailed discussions on the "MC14 agenda and explored strategic ways to further deepen our economic cooperation and bilateral trade ties", the Department of Commerce said in a social media post. The meeting is important as the two countries have finalised a framework for the first phase of the bilateral trade agreement. It has not yet been signed.

Power Min directs imported coal-based plant to run at full capacity from April 1

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Power Ministry is believed to have directed imported coal-based thermal plants to operate at full capacity for three months from April 1, to avoid any electricity shortage amid the estimated peak demand of 270GW during this summer. Sources said that in letters sent to imported coal-based plants in the country, the power ministry invoked Section 11 of the Electricity Act, asking them to run at full capacity. The step has been taken to ensure optimal power availability, considering the prevailing demand-supply scenario and the expected rise in electricity demand in the coming months, according to the letter. The ministry has estimated the peak power demand to be over 270GW during this summer season (April onwards). However, during last summer (April 2025 onwards),



the peak power demand was 242.77 GW in June, 2025. According to Government estimates, peak power demand was expected to touch 277 GW in the summer of 2025. The peak power demand touched an all-time high of about 250 GW in May 2024. The previous all-time peak power demand of 243.27 GW

Budget 2026 eases burden on middle class: FM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Wednesday said the Union Budget has taken several "facilitative" measures for the middle class and MSMEs, and the Government is moving forward with reforms not out of compulsion, but with conviction and clarity. Replying to the debate on Finance Bill 2026 in the Lok Sabha, Sitharaman said the fiscal deficit is projected to come down to 4.3 per cent of GDP in FY27, from 9.3 per cent in FY21, and the country's debt-to-GDP ratio is on a declining path and is lower than most major economies. The Lok Sabha passed the Finance Bill 2026, by a voice vote after including 32 Government amendments. The Finance Bill, 2026, Sitharaman said rests on five key principles — trust-based tax administration; ease of living for citizens; empowering farmers, MSMEs and cooperatives; making India stronger global business hub; and seamless trade facilitation and customs reforms. Rejecting opposition charge that the middle class have been left out in the Budget for 2026-27 fiscal year, the minister listed out mea-

sures like reduction in TCS rate on payments made under Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS) for foreign education and medical treatment. Also, TCS on overseas tour packages have been slashed to 2 per cent from 20 per cent earlier. She also said the Finance Bill provided for exempting customs duty on 17 critical drugs and duty-free import of medicines and personal use. Besides, to make life easier for taxpayers, the facility to file updated I-T returns have been allowed even where reassessment proceedings have been initiated, and a foreign asset disclosure scheme for small taxpayers have been brought in. To reduce disputes at airports with customs officers, the Finance Bill provides for rationalising tariffs on gifts and items brought into India. "The passengers will now have far less to worry about when they land in India," she said, adding that these are aimed at facilitating middle class, passengers, ordinary citizens, and are not for high networth individuals. With regard to MSMEs, the Government is taking an approach that is friendly for MSMEs and is moving away from the concept of "penal-



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman speaks in the Lok Sabha during the second part of the Budget Session on Wednesday

ising first and giving them relief later" to "facilitating first, enforcing later". "Individuals or MSMEs have been given more facilitative treatment (in the Finance Bill)," Sitharaman said. Sitharaman said India is riding on the "reform express" with reforms not happening out of compulsion, but out of conviction, clarity, confidence and commitment. She further said there is a trust-based tax administration that is being improved by reducing unnecessary hardship for honest taxpayers. The Government has taken

various steps to empower MSMEs, farmers, and cooperatives because they are at the heart of creation of employment for production and for the overall development of India, she said. The Finance Bill aims to support them with very many measures that improve liquidity but also reduce compliance burden and give them the opportunity to have greater contribution towards the larger economy, she added. Elaborating further on the Bill, the Finance Minister said customs reforms have been proposed by altering many provisions with

India, Taiwan deepen AI collaboration at Convergence India Expo 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Taiwan have stepped up their collaboration in artificial intelligence (AI) and digital infrastructure with the launch of the Taiwan Excellence Pavilion at the Convergence India Expo 2026, being held at Bharat Mandapam from March 23 to 25. Organised by Taiwan's Ministry of Economic Affairs and executed by TAITRA, the pavilion showcases Taiwan's strengths in semiconductors, AI, and AIoT technologies. Built around the theme "Taiwan AI Island," it features over 40 products from 17 leading Taiwanese companies, highlighting solutions across edge AI, industrial computing, data storage,



and smart mobility. Speaking at a press meet, Estela Chen, Executive Director, Economic Division, Taipei Economic and Cultural Center in India, noted that bilateral trade between India and Taiwan has reached a record USD 12.5 billion, reflecting growing economic ties and

investment opportunities. She emphasised Taiwan's role in supporting India's Digital India and Smart Cities initiatives. Company representatives from firms such as Phison, ADLINK, IBASE, Lanner, and Wincomm demonstrated advanced AI applications in industrial automation, edge comput-

ing, and network security. The pavilion also featured cultural performances and was attended by actor Taapsee Pannu. It will host interactive sessions and business engagements throughout the expo, fostering deeper industry collaboration between the two sides.



India and the US announced a trade deal on February 2. A joint statement for the same was released on February 7. India remains engaged with the US for a mutually beneficial trade agreement. According to the framework, the US had agreed to reduce tariffs on India to 18 per cent. However, the tariff architecture in the US has changed following its Supreme Court ruling against President Donald Trump's sweeping tariffs. After that, the US

President imposed 10 per cent tariffs on all countries for 150 days from February 24. In view of these changes, a meeting of the chief negotiators of India and the US has been postponed. They were scheduled to meet last month to finalise the legal text of the pact, which was expected to be signed this month. An official has earlier stated that the interim trade agreement between India and the US will be signed once the new global tariff architecture of America is in place.

Mahadev app: ED attaches ₹1,700 cr worth assets including in Dubai's Burj Khalifa



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Wednesday said it attached fresh immovable assets worth about ₹1,700 crore, majorly located in Dubai including in the iconic Burj Khalifa, belonging to one of the main promoters of the Mahadev App, Sourabh Chandrakar, as part of its money laundering investigation. The federal probe agency has said that the case involves various high-ranking politicians and bureaucrats from Chhattisgarh. A provisional order was issued by the Raipur zonal office of the federal agency under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) on Wednesday to attach 18 "high-value" luxury villas and apartments in Dubai Hills Estate, including in Hills View, Fairway Residency and Sidra, the agency said in a statement. It added that multiple "high-end" apartments in

Business Bay and SLS Hotel & Residences, apart from apartments in Burj Khalifa, have also been attached. The Burj Khalifa is the world's tallest building at 829.8 metres. Two immovable properties located in Delhi have also been attached under the said order. All these assets have a fair market value of about ₹1,700 crore, it said. "The properties belong to Sourabh Chandrakar, one of the main promoters of the Mahadev Online Book betting application and held in the name of entities controlled by him, his associates including Vikas Chhaparia, Rohit Gulati, Atul Arora, Nitin Tibrewal, Surendra Bagri," the ED said. The Mahadev app was co-promoted by Chandrakar and his associate Ravi Uppal, both of whom hail from Chhattisgarh. India is pursuing their extradition. While the last known location of Chandrakar was in the United Arab Emirates (UAE), Uppal is stated to have fled to Vanuatu from the UAE.

99th birthday celebration of veteran at Mizoram



TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The Territorial Army under the aegis of 23 Sector Assam Rifles, celebrated the 99th birthday of Padma Shri Havildar Lalbiakthanga Pachuau (Retired), a distinguished veteran of the 3rd Battalion, The Assam Regiment. At 99 years of age, Havildar Pachuau stands as a living embodiment of the

finest traditions of the Indian Army. Having served with distinction in the 3rd Battalion, The Assam Regiment, including participation during World War II, he later transitioned into a remarkable civilian life dedicated to journalism, literature, and social service on voluntary retirement from the Army after completing 17 years of service.



He was conferred the Padma Shri in 2021 in recognition of his distinguished contribution to Literature and Education (journalism), being widely acknowledged as India's oldest working journalist, and for his lifelong efforts in promoting truthful reporting, social awareness, and community development in Mizoram. Under the theme "A Remarkable Century, A

Remarkable Life," all ranks of Territorial Army, Assam Regiment and Assam Rifles paid tribute to this illustrious son of the Regiment. The family members of the veteran and ex-servicemen joined the celebration with enthusiasm. His life continues to inspire generations, reinforcing the enduring bond between veterans and serving soldiers.

BRIEFLY

Jakson Group signs Ganguly as brand ambassador



Energy and infrastructure conglomerate, Jakson Group has signed former India cricket captain Sourav Ganguly as its first ever brand ambassador. As part of this association, Ganguly will represent Jakson Group across key brand campaigns and strategic initiatives for a sustainable energy ecosystem. "Jakson's vision across entire value chain of distributed power, solar energy, green molecules, and infrastructure - power, metro, civil, and water, is both timely and impactful. I am excited to associate with a brand contributing meaningfully to India's energy transition and a greener future," Ganguly said on the association. Sameer Gupta, chairman of Jakson Group added: "This partnership reflects a shared belief in staying ahead and delivering consistently. With his credibility, we are confident this association will strengthen our brand and accelerate adoption of our sustainable solutions across India and globally."

Wilson says Zoravar left out due to workload management



India's foreign trap coach Peter Wilson on Wednesday said that the country's top trap marksman Zoravar Singh Sandhu has been left out from the season-opening ISSF Shotgun World Cup due to "workload management". The 12-member Indian contingent is all set for the World Cup in Tangier, but conspicuous by his absence is Zoravar, the World Championships bronze medallist who became only the third Indian trap shooter to win a medal on the big stage last year. En route to Tangier, Wilson, the London Olympic gold medallist, told PTI that the 46-year-old stalwart Zoravar will return to the side "hundred percent", with next year being crucial for Indian shooting as qualification for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics begins. Zoravar is currently ranked fourth in the world and given his global ranking he should have been India's best bet but Wilson said, "So, whether Zoravar was first, second, third, or last in the world, it would still mean that we would manage his workload and he wouldn't be expected to shoot every competition." "We've got good depth, and my intention is that they all get the chance to compete on the world stage. But with regard to Zoravar, as I said, the best would be to contact the National Rifle Association of India (NRAI)," said Wilson before boarding his flight for Morocco.

Asia Cup Stage 1: Indian archers win two bronze

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Bangkok

Indian archers bagged two bronze medals and also stormed into the finals of the men's recurve and women's compound team events on the second day of the Asia Cup World Ranking Tournament Stage 1 here on Wednesday. India also confirmed three medals in the individual section, but it came with the embarrassment for the recurve men, where none of the four archers could reach the medal rounds in a sharp fall from the previous edition's top-two finish by Vishnu Choudhary and Rahul. The women's compound team improved on its bronze from the previous edition by



reaching the final. The trio of Chikitha Taniparthi, Raj Kaur and Tejal Salve edged past local favourites Kanyavee Maneesombatkul, Kanoknapus Kaewchomphu and Chaniddapa Thanaratpitinan 229-226 in a closely-fought semifinal to set up a summit clash against third-seeded Kazakhstan. However, there was some disappointment in the men's compound section, where India fielded one of their most experienced combinations.

Despite topping the qualification round with Indian archers sweeping the top four spots, the team failed to defend its title and had to settle for a bronze. The trio of Rajat Chauhan, Rishabh Yadav and Uday Kambojsquandered a strong five-point lead to lose 233-234 to Vietnam in the semifinals. India began with a perfect opening end but faltered in the second, managing 57 while Vietnam's Cong Duc Dang, Ngoc Tu Pham and Xuan Huong Tran shot a perfect 60 to cut the deficit. The Vietnamese continued their surge with another perfect 60 in the third end to overturn the deficit and take a one-point lead. Both teams shot 59 in the final end, sealing India's narrow defeat. The Indians, however, bounced back to beat Bhutan 234-232 in the bronze medal match. In the recurve section, India entered the men's team final with a 5-1 win over Malaysia. The top-seeded trio of Devaang Gupta, Sukhchain Singh and Juyel Sarkar won comfortably without dropping a set. India took the opening set 53-50 and edged the second 53-52 in a low-scoring contest. Both teams improved in the third set, with India shooting four 10s, but it ended in a 56-all tie which was just enough to send India into the final, where they will meet third-seeded Kazakhstan.

Mansukh Mandaviya lauds Indian lacrosse teams for winning Asian gold

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi

Set for an Olympic return after 100 years, the lesser known sport of lacrosse got acknowledgement from Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on Wednesday as he felicitated the Indian men's and women's teams for their gold-winning show at a recent Asian meet and urged them to eye 2028 Los Angeles Games qualification. Lacrosse is a native American team sport in which a long-handled stick with a netted head is used to catch, pass and



throw a rubber ball into the rival goal. It made its Olympic debut as a medal event in 1904 and featured again four years later before becoming a demonstration discipline in 1928, 1932 and 1948. Eventually dropped from the roster, the sport will return to the Games in the upcoming Los Angeles edition. "Lacrosse is an upcoming big sport for India. This was your first major international exposure and you have already brought home

medals. Now the focus should be on working harder, gaining more exposure and making the country proud by aiming for qualification at LA 2028," Mandaviya told the two teams. India delivered a dominant performance at the Asian Lacrosse Games held in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia in February, securing gold medals in both the men's and women's events in the six-a-side format, which will be used in Los Angeles as well. Indian men and women defeated Iraq and Pakistan respectively in their final matches.

Los Angeles Golf Club wins SoFi Cup

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Palm Beach Gardens (US)

Tiger Woods competed for the first time in more than a year and that wasn't nearly enough to stop Los Angeles Golf Club, which made three straight eagles to close out a 9-2 victory in the TGL final to capture the SoFi Cup. Woods had been captain and cheer-leader for Jupiter Links as he recovered from back surgery in October. He decided Monday evening after Los Angeles rallied to win the first match in the best-of-3 series that he was ready to play, replacing Kevin Kisner. His biggest moment was missing a 3-foot putt on the seventh hole on Tuesday, slamming his putter to the turf in disgust. That gave LA momentum, and it turned so quickly the 15-hole match ended in 10 holes. "We got our (butts) kicked at the end," Woods said. "Three eagles in a row. I missed a



short one to give them momentum and we never got it back." Woods had said earlier playing TGL was just a step. He gave no indication when it was over whether he would play in the Masters on April 9-12. "This body ... it doesn't recover like it did when it was 24, 25. It doesn't mean I'm not trying," Woods said. "I've had a couple bad injuries here

over the past years that I've had to fight through and it's taken some time. But I keep trying." "I want to play. I love the tournament," he said. "I'm going to be there either way with The Loop that's going up there, as well as the Champions Dinner. ... We'll see how it goes. I'll be practicing, playing at home this week and keep trying to make progress." His short miss gave LA its first lead at 3-2, and Tommy Fleetwood followed by making a 12-foot eagle putt on the reachable par-4 eighth. Max Homa had suggested earlier throwing a hammer - that makes the hole worth two points - if Jupiter took advantage on a par 5 during alternate shot. That backfired. Fleetwood drove into a bunker, and Woods hit 3-wood to keep it short of the bunker. Homa hit the approach to 15 feet for an eagle chance, but Justin Rose hit a beauty out of the bunker to just inside 15 feet.



BCB chief Bashar wants long-term return of Shakib Al Hasan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Dhaka

The Bangladesh Cricket Board's newly-appointed chairman of selectors Habibul Bashar says he wants veteran all-rounder Shakib Al Hasan to return to the country and play for at least two more years, including the 2027 ODI World Cup. The 39-year-old Shakib, who was a member of the Sheikh Hasina-led Awami League party, relocated to the USA after her government was toppled by a violent student uprising in 2024. The interim government barred him from representing the country. But Bashar, who took charge after the formation of a new government earlier this year, took a conciliatory tone towards the veteran. Bashar said he is being considered for a return but it would not be during the upcoming home white-ball series against New Zealand starting April 17 as time is not enough to plan it out. "There is not much time left before the New Zealand series and I am not sure how much cricket Shakib has been involved with. From what I know about him, he is not a guy who will come tomorrow and play the day after. "He needs preparation too. It's not a place of emotion. Definitely if we are thinking about Shakib, we will think in the long-term," Bashar was quoted as saying by 'Cricbuzz'. Shakib has often expressed a desire to play his last Test on home turf before calling it quits but Bashar said the celebrated cricketer still has at least two more years left in him. "I don't think about Shakib coming for a single series and then leaving. If we can get service from him, we will want that he provides that for a long time. In that regard, preparation is very important. "First things first, he is definitely in the plans. You see there are talks about him in regards to the New Zealand series which is why I want him to come prepared for a longer time. I think he still has two years," Bashar said. "I want him for the longer term, at least to have that plan where he can play the 2027 World Cup. So my plans are not for one series," he added.

Mohamed Salah to leave Liverpool at end of the season

STEVE DOUGLAS

Liverpool (England)

Liverpool star Mohamed Salah announced that he will leave the English club at the end of the season, marking an earlier-than-planned departure for one of the club's greatest-ever scorers and soccer's biggest names. The 33-year-old Egypt forward, who has scored 255 goals in 435 appearances for Liverpool, "reached an agreement" to quit the team a year before his contract was due to expire, the Premier League champions said on Tuesday. Salah's form has dipped in his ninth year at Anfield, to such an extent that he was dropped for a stretch of games late last year — leading to the winger telling reporters



in an impromptu interview that the club "has thrown me under the bus." "Unfortunately the day has come," Salah said in a post on Instagram that was released around the same time as

Liverpool published a six-paragraph statement announcing the imminent departure of a club great. "I never imagined," he added, "how deeply this club, this city, these people would

become part of my life. Liverpool is not just a football club. It's a passion, it's a history, it's a spirit. I can't explain in words to anyone not part of this club." Liverpool describes Salah as one of its greatest players: It's a slightly acrimonious exit for Salah, who has been the superstar name in Liverpool's greatest team in a generation. He has won two Premier Leagues and a Champions League in a total of eight titles since joining from Roma in 2017, initially forming a devastating front three with Sadio Mane and Roberto Firmino under manager Jurgen Klopp. Salah is third in Liverpool's all-time scorers' list, behind Ian Rush and Roger Hunt, and has won the Golden Boot —

as the Premier League's top scorer — four times. Liverpool described Salah as "one of the greatest players in Liverpool's history" and said his time at Anfield had been "remarkable." "Salah expressed his wish to make this announcement to the supporters at the earliest possible opportunity," Liverpool said, "to provide transparency about his future due to his respect and gratitude for them." There was no immediate word from Salah on his next club. Leaving as a free agent would mean Liverpool wouldn't collect a transfer fee. Salah was previously the subject of a bid from a Saudi team, reportedly Al-Ittihad, that was turned down in 2023. (AP)

A look at Salah's trophy-laden career at Liverpool, in numbers

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Liverpool (England)

Mohamed Salah has announced he will leave Liverpool at the end of this season, bringing to a close a trophy-laden nine-year spell at the club. Here's a by-the-numbers look at his time at Anfield. 4: The number of Golden Boot awards won by Salah at Liverpool for being the top scorer in the Premier League, tied for the most with Arsenal great Thierry Henry. Salah's came in 2017-18, 2018-19, 2021-22 and 2024-25. 8: The number of major titles won by Salah at Liverpool: two Premier



League, one Champions League, one FA Cup, two League Cups, the Club World Cup and the UEFA Super Cup. 50 million: The fee, in US dollars, Liverpool spent to sign Salah from Roma in 2017.

255: The number of goals Salah has scored at Liverpool, putting him third on its all-time list behind Ian Rush (346) and Roger Hunt (285). 435: The number of appearances made by Salah for Liverpool in all competitions.

World Cup playoffs: Italy on edge, Sweden shorn of stars and another chance for Lewandowski

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Bergamo (Italy)

When Fabio Cannavaro raised aloft the golden World Cup trophy inside Berlin's Olympic Stadium in 2006, few could have imagined the pain soccer's biggest event would inflict on Italy over the next two decades. In 2010, the Azzurri put up a woeful title defense, not even winning a game in an embarrassing group-stage exit. In 2014, they again didn't reach the knockout stage, dumped out by a Uruguay goal scored soon after Luis Suarez bit Italy defender Giorgio Chiellini. As for the 2018 and 2022 tournaments, the Italians didn't even get there, eliminat-

ed in the European playoffs in an utter humiliation for a soccer-mad nation. No wonder the country is on edge this week. Italy is back in the World Cup playoffs, one of 16 European teams competing for the four remaining spots from the continent for this summer's tournament in the United States, Canada and Mexico. The World Cup has never been bigger, enlarged to 48 countries including 16 from Europe. And still Italy needs to get in via the back door, a bad look for a four-time world champion and a traditional hotbed for the sport. Standing in Italy's way in the playoff semifinals taking place

across Europe on Thursday will be Northern Ireland in Bergamo. Win that — and the Azzurri are big favorites — and they'll need to beat either Wales or Bosnia and Herzegovina to advance to the World Cup. Italy is undoubtedly the big story from the playoff. Here are some more things to watch out for: Sweden shorn of its big names: It's crunch time for Graham Potter. The former Chelsea and West Ham coach was hired by Sweden last year, initially on a short-term deal and with one task — get the team to the World Cup. That is still to be determined but Potter has clearly done enough in the meantime



to impress the federation, which handed him a contract to 2030 last week. It's quite the show of support for Potter ahead of the playoffs, where Sweden faces

war-torn Ukraine on neutral territory in Valencia, Spain. The winner will host Poland or Albania next week. Unfortunately for Potter, he hasn't got all of his big names

available, with Premier League stars Alexander Isak and Dejan Kulusevski injured. Ukraine still hosting matches on the road: Exactly four years ago, Ukraine could not play a scheduled World Cup qualifying playoffs semifinal in Scotland in the turmoil just weeks after the full Russian military invasion. Ukraine eventually won 3-1 in Glasgow in June 2022 then lost the playoff final four days later in Wales to a goal by Gareth Bale. Ukraine is back in the playoffs after four years of being unable to host any games on its own territory still being bombed by Russia, which remains banned from international soccer.

Lewandowski's last chance?: It's always dangerous to write off the careers of soccer's top players — Portugal star Cristiano Ronaldo is likely headed to the World Cup at age 41, for example — but this might be Robert Lewandowski's final shot at a World Cup. The 37-year-old Barcelona striker had a brief spell away from Poland's national team last year, making himself unavailable after he was stripped of the captaincy by then-coach Michal Probiez. Probiez resigned after Poland lost to Finland without Lewandowski, who promptly returned to the squad in August under new coach Jan Urban. Poland's all-time top

scorer regained the captain's armband, too. Lewandowski has recently been wearing a protective mask on his face during games after suffering fractured left eye socket. Kosovo has been in a hurry: Kosovo was two games away from the World Cup, fewer than 10 years since the national team was out of the international soccer family. It was in May 2016 that Kosovo and Gibraltar were voted into FIFA as its 210th and 211th member federations. That was eight years after Kosovo declared independence from Serbia in a move still not recognized by dozens of United Nations member states.

RCB deal nears \$2 billion with ₹540 crore payout for WPL

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The sale of cricket franchise Royal Challengers Bangalore (RCB) by United Spirits Ltd (USL) almost tops a record \$2 billion (₹18,776 crore), considering it also includes a ₹540 crore payout for the Women's Premier League and a 5 per cent commission to the cricket body BCCI by the consortium of buyers, according to sources.

On Tuesday, USL, part of multinational alcoholic beverages company Diageo, announced sale of its 100 per cent equity stake in Royal Challengers Sports Private Ltd (RCSPL) to a consortium in a ₹16,660 crore (nearly \$1.7 billion) all-cash deal.

The acquiring consortium includes Aditya Birla Group, The Times of India Group, Bolt Ventures (a private investment platform of David Blitzer, one of the most prominent sports investors in the world), and Blackstone, the world's largest alternative asset manager.

RCSPL owns and operates the Royal Challengers Bangalore (RCB) franchise that participates in the Indian Premier League (IPL) and Women's Premier League (WPL), it added. "The enterprise value of the deal is close to ₹18,000 crore, adjusted for transaction liabilities to BCCI and debt-like items. That makes it closer to a USD 2 billion valuation," a source said.

The deal is subject to customary conditions, including the receipt of all prerequisite approvals as required to give effect to the proposed transaction, including from the Competition Commission of India and the Board of Control for Cricket in India, as per the conditions set out in the Share Purchase Agreement (SPA).

RCPL's revenue was ₹504 crore in FY25 and had contributed 1.9 per cent in the topline of Diageo India, which has brands as Johnnie Walker, Black Dog, Black & White, VAT 69, Antiquity, Signature, The Singleton, Royal Challenge, McDowell's Smirnoff, and Tanqueray in its fold.

USL expects deal to be



completed in the next six months subject to fulfilment of the conditions of SPA.

"Subject to fulfilment of terms and conditions as under the SPA, the completion of the Proposed Transaction is expected to occur within 6 months from the date hereof, subject to any extension agreed in accordance with the terms of the SPA," said USL in a regulatory filing.

The SPA also has a co-existence arrangement governing the usage of certain brand names as between USL and RCSPL, each of which will be entered into only upon completion of the proposed transaction and effective therefrom, it said.

Following the transaction, Aryaman Vikram Birla, Director, Aditya Birla Group, will serve as Chairman and Satyan Gajwani of The Times of India Group will serve as Vice Chairman of the franchise.

Commenting on the deal, Aditya Birla Group Chairman, Kumar Mangalam Birla said, "over the past 2 decades, the IPL has morphed to become a global sporting powerhouse that has changed the face of Indian cricket creating enormous value for India. RCB, as one of the most compelling franchises in modern sport, offers the Aditya Birla Group a distinctive platform to extend its legacy of institution-building into the arena of global sport."



ODI WC crown gave us confidence to win titles anywhere: Harmanpreet

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India women's cricket team captain Harmanpreet Kaur on Wednesday said last year's ODI World Cup crown at home gave the side much-needed confidence and self belief to win more titles anywhere in the world.

India defeated South Africa in Navi Mumbai to win their maiden ICC title in November last year.

And that achievement has instilled self belief in the side to repeat the feat in the Women's T20 World Cup, to be staged in the United Kingdom from June 12 to July 5.

"Look, I believe that in any field, you have to do something special, you have to win a title, only then do you get recognition. Otherwise, it feels like all the hard work goes to waste," Harmanpreet on the sidelines of the naming ceremony of a stand in her honour at the Omaxe Stadium in Dwarka.

"Not just our team, but all the women cricketers before us have put in immense effort, often even spending from their own pockets. So, winning a title was very important. And after achieving that, the response we are getting from Indian fans, the media, and everyone else is a very big thing for us."

Talking about the huge expectations from fans to repeat the feat in this year's T20 World Cup, the skipper said: "We'll try our best (to win T20 World Cup). Last World Cup gave us confidence, and now we have the belief that we can win the World Cup anywhere in the world."

India toured Australia recently for a multi-format series, which included three T20Is, as many ODIs and a one-off pink ball Test.

India lost the series 4-12 on points, but according to Harmanpreet the tour was a big learning experience.

"Such a multi-format series should happen because it gives you a lot of challenges. After every week, you have to play a different format, so I think this is a totally different experience," she said.

Esterhuizen blasts South Africa to 33-run win in 5th T20 against New Zealand

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Christchurch

Connor Esterhuizen blasted a career-best 75 from 33 balls to propel South Africa to a 33-run win over New Zealand in the fifth Twenty20 on Wednesday and a 3-2 win in the five-match series.

Esterhuizen's second consecutive half-century after his previous best of 57 in the fourth match on Sunday saw South Africa make 187-4 after being sent in.

New Zealand managed only 154-8 in reply.

Esterhuizen paced the second half of the South Africa innings after coming to the crease in the 11th over with total 76-2. He was dropped a place in the order Wednesday and batted behind Rubin

Hermann who hit 39 from 31 balls to pick up the run-rate after a slow start.

South Africa was only 43-1 after the power play and 76 at the midpoint of its innings. The last 10 overs produced 111 runs, thanks to Esterhuizen and Dian Forrester with whom he added 61 in just over four overs for the fourth wicket.

"I think the nice thing was that I got to come in and play with some freedom because of the nice platform from the guys up top with wickets in hand," Esterhuizen said. "Early on the openers assessed it and said 160 was competitive. The more myself and (Forrester) was out there we said 170 was a good score and we got 187."

Esterhuizen's innings included five fours and six



sixes. He was dropped on 49 by Bevon Jacobs from the bowling of Zak Foulkes and made New Zealand pay, stretching his innings into the last over. In total the South Africa innings contained 15 fours and 10 sixes along with 47 dot balls.

With wickets in hand South Africa added 52 runs from the last five overs, including

five sixes. New Zealand's problems were compounded by poor catching, though Nick Kelly held a brilliant one-handed catch, the best of the series, to dismiss Hermann.

The New Zealand run chase was also poorly executed and the home side found itself bogged down by accurate bowling, well supported by the field.

Gerald Coetzee bowled quick at both ends of the innings and took 2-21 from four overs while Ottnell Baartman used variation and took 2-33. The spinner Prenelan Subrayen allowed only 22 runs from his four overs and captain Keshav Maharaj also tested the New Zealand batters.

New Zealand was 46-2 after the power play and 65-3 after 10 overs when the run rate required was 12.3 per over. After 15 overs New Zealand was 116-4 and the required run rate had crept up to 14.4. New Zealand finally needed 47 from the last two overs.

Jacobs was the best of the New Zealand batters, scoring 36 from 19.

The match was the most high-scoring of the series. New Zealand was bowled out for 91 in the first match which South Africa won by seven wickets; South Africa was bowled out for 107 in the second match which New Zealand won by 68 runs and held to 136-9 in the third match which New Zealand won by eight wickets. South Africa restricted New Zealand to 145 in the fourth match which it won by 19 runs.

RR captain Riyan Parag invests ₹2 crore in tech start-up Proxgy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Rajasthan Royals captain Riyan Parag has invested Rs 2-crore in Proxgy, one of the country's fastest-growing innovation-led 'Make in India' product and technology companies.

With this investment, Parag joins a growing league of cricketers backing Proxgy, including Kolkata Knight Riders captain Ajinkya Rahane.

Proxgy has won the Graham Bell Award, CES Innovation Awards, European Product Design Awards, and NASSCOM's League of 10, among others.



The company has also captured nationwide attention as one of the highest-funded startups.

"What drew me to Proxgy was the balance they've achieved between innovation and execution," Parag stated in a release.

"They're building products that stand out immediately, but what truly impressed me was the thinking behind them, especially the focus on safety and accessibility for blue-collar workers who operate in challenging environments every day. It's rare to see innovation so closely aligned with real, on-ground impact."



Pant should bat at No. 3: Faf du Plessis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Former South Africa captain Faf du Plessis feels Rishabh Pant should bat at No. 3 position to maximise his impact, and also urged the hard-hitting wicketkeeper-batter to control his high-risk approach and aim for consistency in the upcoming IPL.

Pant shuffled his batting position from being No. 4 to opener and also lower down the order in a woeful last season. But he finally produced his best at No. 3 — a 61-ball unbeaten 118 in Lucknow Super Giants' (LSG) last league match.

"Maybe there is an opportunity for Pant to bat at number three," said du Plessis speaking on JioStar's 'IPL Today Live'.

"The numbers suggest that for him to be the best player he can be, number three looks good. I see him batting at number three for LSG this season with Nicholas Pooran sliding down to number four.

"Looking at LSG's 2026 auction and their strategy around who they signed, you look at that top-heavy batting line-up — Aiden Markram, Mitchell Marsh and Pooran are the main ones alongside Pant," added the former RCB skipper. Pant heads into the new season with significant expectations after being bought for a record Rs 27 crore ahead of IPL 2025. However, his first stint as captain of LSG was underwhelming as they finished seventh. He endured an inconsistent campaign, scoring 269 runs in 13 innings at an average of 24.45 with a strike rate just over 133.

"When I look at him, he is almost like a highlight player. I want him to be more of a high-impact player in terms of what he can give in his numbers," du Plessis said.

"He needs to figure out exactly what his game plan looks like to give himself the best chance."

The IPL 2026 begins with defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru facing Sunrisers Hyderabad in the opener in Bengaluru on Saturday, while LSG start their campaign against Delhi Capitals at home on April 1.

Safety measures there to handle extreme scenarios: FIDE

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The International Chess Federation (FIDE) on Wednesday sought to downplay security concerns surrounding the upcoming Candidates Tournament in Cyprus, insisting that safety measures and contingency plans are in place to deal with "extreme" scenarios.

Cyprus is geographically close to West Asia, which is currently in the middle of a military conflict that started with American and Israeli bombing of Iran.

The island nation endured a drone attack on a British air base that it houses earlier this month.

Citing security apprehensions, Indian Grandmaster Koneru Humpy pulled out of the tournament, that will decide the challenger for the men's and women's world titles. The Candidates tournament begins this Saturday.

"Cyprus is a safe country to travel. There is no emergency situation, and the country continues to operate normally. All necessary measures are in place to ensure a secure, comfortable, and well-organised environment for all participants, media, and guests," the FIDE said on Wednesday, addressing concerns that have also been voiced by another prominent Candidates competitor, Hikaru Nakamura.

Nakamura, who has been in Cyprus for the past few weeks, has stated that he



experienced disruptive power cuts during his stay, which cannot be a good sign. FIDE said the risk of power cuts is extremely low and "overstated".

"Power shortages in Cyprus are very rare and typically short-lived. For example, a recent incident, which caused outages in some areas of Cyprus on

March 13, lasted only several minutes before full restoration.

"In addition, the tournament venue — Cap St Georges Hotel & Resort — is fully equipped with backup power generators, ensuring uninterrupted electricity supply throughout the event," it said.

The world body, which has previously declared that the situation in Cyprus does not warrant a change of venues, also said safety measures are in place for "extreme scenarios."

"As a precautionary measure, the hotel is equipped with its own shelter facilities. While such scenarios are purely theoretical, appropriate infrastructure is in place to ensure the safety of all participants and guests.

"The venue is located in the western part of Cyprus, away from sensitive or strategic military locations. It is not situated along any routes related to the Middle East crisis," it said.

Citing normal flight operations in the country, FIDE said it is closely monitoring the situation and remains in contact with the Cyprus authorities to mitigate any potential risks.

"FIDE has contingency plans in place, as with any major international event. We remain ready to respond promptly to any changes in circumstances, with the safety and comfort of players, officials, media, and guests as the top priority," it said.

Bharti joins India camp ahead of Asian Cup qualifier vs Hong Kong

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Nepal-born defender Abneet Bharti has joined the Indian senior men's team camp in Kochi ahead of the AFC Asian Cup qualifier against Hong Kong, the AIFF said on Wednesday.

The development comes a day after Ryan Williams was named in the squad for the same fixture. As things stand, India now have two foreign-based players in the camp for the first time — 27-year-old defender Bharti and 32-year-old winger Williams who recently obtained his Indian passport.

Williams had missed the Bangladesh match as his FIFA clearance arrived late and the Bengaluru FC player is now set for his much-anticipated India debut against Hong Kong on March 31.

India are already out of contention for the 2027 AFC Asian Cup in Saudi Arabia and are now looking to rebuild the side. With experienced defender Sandesh Jhingan in the bag end of his career, the team is in need of a reliable centre-back alongside Anwar Ali, and Bharti could be an option if he gets clearance.

Yet to make his senior international debut but in contention for two awards at the upcoming Hockey India annual gala, young goalkeeper Prince Deep Singh said the twin nominations have silenced self-doubt and fuelled ambition in him.

The 21-year-old, currently training at the senior men's national camp, is nominated in two of the biggest categories — Hockey India Baljit Singh Award for Goalkeeper of the Year 2025 and Hockey India Jugraj Singh Award for Upcoming Player of the Year 2025 (Men U-21). The eighth edition of the annual awards is to be held here on Friday.

"I feel very happy and proud. It usually takes time to get nominated for such awards, but I got this opportunity early. Performing well in tournaments and seeing my name among top goalkeepers - it motivates me a lot," he said.

"India has a strong pool of

goalkeepers. To be nominated among them, even before my senior debut, feels special. It gives me confidence that I am on the right path.

"That belief is perhaps the biggest takeaway from this recognition — a validation that is helping silence self-doubt and fuel ambition. This clears a lot of doubts I had about myself. Now I know I'm doing something right. I just want to keep improving and build on this," he added.

Prince Deep won a gold medal at the FIH Junior Asia Cup in 2024, a silver at the Sultan of Johor Cup in 2025, and a bronze at the FIH Men's Junior World Cup in Chennai last year.

He was also named



'Goalkeeper of the Tournament' in the Hockey India League (HIL) 2025-26, where he played for Accord Tamil Nadu Dragons.

His journey to this moment has been shaped by performances under pressure.

At the FIH Junior World Cup, where India clinched bronze, Prince Deep stood tall in crunch situations, particularly during India's quarter-final against Belgium — a match that tested not just his skill, but temperament.